



22. NIMBLE LEARNING

Actively learning through experimentation when tackling new problems, using both successes and failures as learning fodder.

Most of us are good at applying what we have seen and done in the past and utilizing solutions that have worked for us before. A rarer skill is doing things for the first time. Solving problems we've never come across. Trying solutions we have never tried before. Analyzing problems in new contexts and in new ways. With the increasing pace of change, being quick to learn and apply first-time solutions is becoming a crucial skill. It involves taking risks, being less than perfect, discarding the past, going against the grain, and cutting new paths. It requires patience, persistence, and a positive attitude. Organizations need people who can quickly adapt their thinking to the current situation. People who can draw on their past experience and apply the learning to a new and different setting. To become a nimble learner is to be engaged in the present while drawing on past learnings and thinking about future needs. Ask good questions. Learn from experience. Be willing to try new things. And be flexible in the face of new or changing information.



*"Negative results are just what I want.
They're as valuable to me as positive results.
I can never find the thing that does the job best
until I find the ones that don't."*

Thomas Edison – American inventor and businessman

Nimble learning is in the **Self** factor (IV) in the Korn Ferry Leadership Architect™. It is part of Cluster L, **Being flexible and adaptable**, along with *Manages ambiguity* (3), *Being resilient* (26), and *Situational adaptability* (31). You may find it helpful to also take a look at some of the tips included in those chapters to supplement your learning.

Skilled

- ★ **Learns quickly when facing new situations.**
- ★ **Experiments to find new solutions.**
- ★ **Takes on the challenge of unfamiliar tasks.**
- ★ **Extracts lessons learned from failures and mistakes.**

Less skilled

- Struggles to learn in new situations.
- Becomes frustrated or confused by unfamiliar tasks.
- Gives up on new ideas too soon.
- Resists taking a chance on untested solutions.

Talented

- Tries multiple times using multiple methods to find the right solution.
- Views mistakes as opportunities to learn.
- Enjoys the challenge of unfamiliar tasks.
- Seeks new approaches to solve problems.

Overused skill

- Takes on new challenges for the sake of it rather than in the interest of making a positive impact.
- Focuses on unvetted ideas simply because they are new.
- May take unnecessary risks in the name of learning.

Some possible causes of lower skill

Causes help explain *why* a person may have trouble with Nimble learning. When seeking to increase skill, it's helpful to consider how these might play out in certain situations. And remember that all of these can be addressed if you are motivated to do so.

- Isn't willing to ask questions.
- Fails to look outside of the box.
- Doesn't analyze successes and failures for clues.

- Solves problems based only on what has worked in the past.
- Isn't a risk taker.
- Isn't self-confident.
- Perfectionist.
- Stuck in the past.
- Can't do more than one thing at a time.
- Doesn't have learning role models.
- Poor observer of others.



Brain booster

Believe you can't teach an old dog new tricks? Early scientific research supported the mindset that there are specific periods in a person's life when they learn certain capabilities. Language. Vision. Social attachment. And once that period has passed, the learning stops. The capabilities become hardwired and hard to change. For instance, the first 8–10 months is critical for a child in learning to detect phonetic distinctions in speech. By 12 months, this ability diminishes. The "fixed" mindset supports this view. However, the growing evidence for neuroplasticity in the past two decades has challenged this. Neuroplasticity refers to the brain's ability to adapt and change as a result of effort and experiences. And not just through childhood. The physical structure of the brain continues to change, which means that our learning is not limited in the way early research suggested. This is good news for nimble learning. The brain is sensitive to experience, meaning even old dogs can and do learn new tricks if they're willing to try new things, take risks, and dive into the unfamiliar.

Tips to develop Nimble learning

1. **Facing a new or unknown situation? Embrace ambiguity.** Not many people are motivated by uncertainty and chaos. But sometimes they can bring rewards. Envision the payoff of the unknown and you'll become more comfortable being a pioneer. Solving problems no one has solved before. Cutting paths where no one has been before. Instead of getting overwhelmed by the problem, seek to find a solution. Ask yourself questions. What do you know about the situation? How can you use your experience/expertise and relate it to the setting? Where do you need insight from others? Look for opportunities to gain exposure to new situations, new perspectives, and new insights. Become comfortable with the unknown. Be curious.
2. **Too focused on a solution? Take time to ask questions and define the problem.** Too often we think first and only of solutions. It's easy and tempting. In studies of problem-solving sessions, solutions outweigh questions eight to one. Most meetings on a problem start with people offering solutions. Early solutions are not likely to be the best. If you move to decisions too quickly, analyze the factors that cause you to avoid taking the time to consider complexity. Set aside the first 50% of the time for questions and problem definition and the last 50% of the time for solutions. Asking more questions early helps you rethink the problem and come to more and different solutions. Ask how many elements this problem has. What is related to it? What is not related to it? What are the root causes? Sometimes by understanding the cause, the best solution comes to light. Try to solve the problem as close to the root cause as possible.

3. **Where to start? Locate the essence of the problem.** What are the key factors or elements in this problem? Experts usually solve problems by figuring out what the deep, underlying principles are and working forward from there. The less adept focus on desired outcomes/solutions and work backward or concentrate on the surface facts. What are the deep principles of what you're working on? Once you've done this, search the past for parallels—your past, the business past, the historical past. One common mistake here is to search in parallel organizations because “only they would know.” Backing up and asking a broader question will aid in the search for solutions. When Motorola wanted to find out how to process orders more quickly, they went not to other electronics firms, but to Domino's and Federal Express.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Anthony, S. (2010, July 6). Grooming leaders to handle ambiguity.

Harvard Business Review Blog Network.

Llopis, G. (2013, November 4). The 4 most effective ways leaders solve problems. *Forbes.*

Zwilling, M. (2011, July 19). *Nine steps to effective business problem solving.* Business Insider.

4. **Trouble making sense of the issues? Dig for root causes.** Keep asking why. See how many causes you can come up with and how many organizing buckets you can put them in. This increases the chance of a better solution because you can see more connections. Chess masters recognize thousands of possible patterns of chess pieces. Look for patterns in data. Don't just collect information. Put it in categories that make sense to you.

Use other people to help you best analyze issues. Ask for their understanding of the core problem. Where do they see themes? Draw upon the expertise of others to help you analyze more deeply.

5. How to generalize? Look for patterns. Look for personal patterns, organizational patterns, or world patterns when analyzing general successes and failures. What was common to each success or what was present in each failure but never present in a success? Focus on both the successes and failures. Failures are easier to analyze but don't in themselves tell you what would work. But they give you great incentive to learn, which leads to results. Comparing successes, while less exciting, yields more information about underlying principles. Be careful, though. If you only focus on what went well, you could assume improvement isn't necessary. You might get lazy. By focusing on where you can make improvements, even in successful situations, you can ensure stronger results next time. When analyzing either a success or a failure, it is best to be as specific as possible. Specificity gets to the subtle issues that can make or break a decision in the future. The bottom line is to reduce your insights to principles or rules of thumb you think might be repeatable. When faced with the next new problem, those general underlying principles will apply again.

6. Need help? Use others. Teams of people with the widest diversity of backgrounds produce the most innovative solutions to problems. Get others with different backgrounds to analyze and make sense of the issue with you. When working together, come up with as many questions about it as you can. Set up a

competition with another group or individual. Ask them to work on exactly what you are working on. Have a postmortem to try to deduce some of the practices and procedures that work best. Find a team or individual that faces problems quite similar to what you face and set up dialogues on a number of specific topics. Ask them what they think about when they make decisions. Have them tell you how they thought through a new problem in this area. The major skills they look for in sizing up people's proficiency in this area. Key questions they ask about a problem. How they would suggest you go about learning quickly in this area.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Cherry, K. (n.d.). *What is problem-solving?* About.com Psychology.

Dreifus, C. (2008, January 8). In professor's model, diversity = productivity. *The New York Times*.

Mind Tools. (n.d.). *Root cause analysis: Tracing a problem to its origins*. Mind Tools.

7. Want to speed up the learning cycle? Try different solutions and learn from the results. Don't expect to get it right the first time. Being safe and doing what has worked in the past leads to stale solutions. Instead, be willing to experiment. Many studies show that the second or third try is when we really understand the underlying dynamics of problems. If you have trouble going back the second or third time to get something done, then switch approaches. Sometimes people get stuck in a repeating groove that's not working. Do something different next time. To increase learning, build feedback loops into your experimentation. Aim for

immediate and timely feedback from others. If it's not forthcoming, ask for it. The more frequent the cycles, the more opportunities to learn. Try something new on a regular basis. Instead of looking at learning as a formal process that has to be scheduled, try to learn one new thing every day. This increases your learning opportunities and increases the chance of finding the right answer.

8. Want to innovate but don't know how? Do quick experiments.

Studies show that 80% of innovations occur in unexpected places and by unexpected people. Dye makers developed detergent. Post-it® Notes came from an error in a glue formula. These people were not looking for this solution. They stumbled upon it. They experimented. Build time into your schedule to try new things. Think outside of the box. Pursue a new idea. Try lots of quick, inexpensive experiments to increase the chances of success. Be curious. Draw on ideas from other people. Other industries. Other functional areas. Even if you come up with an idea that you can't use yourself, think about where else it can be applied. Sometimes the best ideas won't work in your area. Will it help in other areas? Can you pass it along?

9. Afraid of failure? Take more risks. Not all new ideas are successful. Prepare yourself for this. About 30%–50% of technical innovations fail in tests within the company. Even among those that make it to the marketplace, 70%–90% fail. The bottom line on change is a 95% failure rate, and the most successful innovators try lots of quick, inexpensive experiments to increase the chances of success. Research indicates that more successful people have made more mistakes than the less successful. Try

new things often. Go for small wins. You can recover quickly if you miss, and more importantly, learn from the results. Start with the easiest challenge, then work up to the tougher ones. Recognize that you won't always be successful. But keep trying. Never give up when you believe there is a way to make something better. Many problem-solving studies show that the second or third try is when we really understand the underlying dynamics of problems. Think of exploring as a series of try-learn-try again-learn some more.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Baldoni, J. (2010, January 29). How to encourage small innovations. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*.

Cain, M. (2013, April 23). 5 Ways to conquer your fear of failure. *Forbes*.

Laufenberg, D. (2010, December). Diana Laufenberg: How to learn? From mistakes [Video file]. TED.

10. Want to use current learning in the future? Reflect. Once you have completed a task or a project, build in time for reflection. The best way to become a nimble learner is to take the time to consider what you have learned from an experience and then apply that learning to future situations. Pause. Reflect. On your own? Take a walk. Journal. Sit in silence. With others? Do a post-project review. Set up an off-site session. Ask questions. What went well? What didn't? How could you have done things differently? If you face a similar challenge in the future, what can you take from this experience to be even more successful? Don't just think about this reflection as a review of the past. Think

forward. What can you take with you to be more successful in future challenges? As you grow, think about your learning journey. What have you learned and developed along the way? How are you thinking about problems from a different perspective now compared to 10 years ago? Five years ago? Three months ago? Last week?

11. Don't see much change or growth? Make learning a priority and a goal. Research indicates that when a person not only seeks to make a good decision but also proactively seeks to learn from an experience, they are more successful in the future. They not only solve the problem but also become a better thinker. This helps the person solve future problems more effectively. When reflecting on the experience, don't just think about the impact of the solution. Consider what you have learned about yourself. What is your best learning style? In what situations would you benefit from using a new or different learning style? What approach is typical for you? What has been most difficult for you in this challenge? Be aware of what is restricting your thinking and perspective. When approaching any new situation, shift your thinking to be learning oriented.

12. Fall back to how you've always done it? Override your default comfort zone. If you find yourself defaulting to the established way of doing things, you're not alone. It turns out our brains are conditioned to be more comfortable with the status quo. We have a natural tendency to stick to what is already known. What we've already decided. What's comfortable. Change of any kind makes our brains work harder than staying the same. The good news is that we can override our brain's natural tendency toward

inertia. How? By constantly trying something new—new ways of doing things, new experiences, new people. There will be challenges for you at first. You're bound to feel a decreased sense of mastery and will likely fail sometimes too. Focus on the payoff—being able to adapt more easily, being out in front of change. This will silence the worry voice inside your head that keeps you tethered to what's comfortable and familiar.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Haque, U. (2010, November 24). Making room for reflection is a strategic imperative. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*.

Latham, G. P., & Seijts, G. (2006, May/June). Learning goals or performance goals: Is it the journey or the destination? *Ivey Business Journal*.

Warrell, M. (2013, April 22). Why getting comfortable with discomfort is crucial to success. *Forbes*.

Job assignments

- Join professional organizations that will build your knowledge and allow you to meet your counterparts from other organizations. Ask them about their approaches, systems, or solutions and assess the relevance to your business.
- Look for opportunities to gain experience working in a cross-cultural setting where you are required to work with people who come from different backgrounds and have different experiences.
- Work on a cross-functional task force where you interact with people from different backgrounds and areas of the organization.

- Volunteer to lead a project or take on a role that is related to your area of expertise where you have less experience.
- Find a mentor. Look for a person who you admire and who demonstrates very strong skills in analyzing issues and solving problems creatively.

Take time to reflect...

If you rely on your past experience when faced with new situations...

...then recognize that what worked before might not always work going forward. A situation may look exactly the same, but there could be differences you're not seeing. Adapt. Try new things.

If you lean toward doing rather than taking time to learn...

...then understand that these aren't mutually exclusive. You're learning every day, even if you don't always stop to think about it. Set aside time to reflect and draw vital lessons from your experiences.

If you prefer to reflect on successes and bury the failures...

...then keep in mind that some of the most powerful learning comes from unsuccessful projects. Studying your mistakes may be painful, but it can turn an experience to forget into a lesson to remember.

*"You don't learn to walk by following rules.
You learn by doing, and by falling over."*

Sir Richard Branson – English business magnate and investor



Learn more about Nimble learning

Bruno, H. E., Gonzalez-Mena, J., Hernandez, L. A., & Sullivan, D. R. (2013). *Learning from the bumps in the road: Insights from early childhood leaders*. St. Paul, MN: Redleaf Press.

Tugend, A. (2011). *Better by mistake: The unexpected benefits of being wrong*. New York, NY: Penguin Group.

Watanabe, K. (2009). *Problem solving 101: A simple book for smart people*. New York, NY: Portfolio Hardcover.

Weinzimmer, L. G., & McConoughey, J. (2013). *The wisdom of failure: How to learn the tough leadership lessons without paying the price*. San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass.

Wilkinson, D. J. (2006). *The ambiguity advantage: What great leaders are great at*. Hampshire, England: Palgrave MacMillan.



Deep dive learning resource links

Anthony, S. (2010, July 6). Grooming leaders to handle ambiguity. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*. Retrieved from <http://blogs.hbr.org/2010/07/grooming-leaders-to-handle-ambiguity/>

Baldoni, J. (2010, January 29). How to encourage small innovations. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*. Retrieved from <http://blogs.hbr.org/2010/01/how-to-encourage-small-i-innov/>

Cain, M. (2013, April 23). 5 Ways to conquer your fear of failure. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/glassheel/2013/04/23/5-ways-to-conquer-your-fear-of-failure/>

Cherry, K. (n.d.). *What is problem-solving?* About.com Psychology. Retrieved from <http://psychology.about.com/od/problemsolving/f/problem-solving-steps.htm>

Dreifus, C. (2008, January 8). In professor's model, diversity = productivity. *The New York Times*. Retrieved from http://www.nytimes.com/2008/01/08/science/08conv.html?_r=0

Haque, U. (2010, November 24). Making room for reflection is a strategic imperative. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*. Retrieved from <http://blogs.hbr.org/2010/11/reflection-items-not-action-it/>

Latham, G. P., & Seijts, G. (2006, May/June). Learning goals or performance goals: Is it the journey or the destination? *Ivey Business Journal*. Retrieved from <http://iveybusinessjournal.com/topics/leadership/learning-goals-or-performance-goals-is-it-the-journey-or-the-destination#.UuwaqdTnZdg>

Laufenberg, D. (2010, December). Diana Laufenberg: How to learn? From mistakes [Video file]. TED. Retrieved from http://www.ted.com/talks/diana_laufenberg_3_ways_to_teach.html

Llopis, G. (2013, November 4). The 4 most effective ways leaders solve problems. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/glennllopis/2013/11/04/the-4-most-effective-ways-leaders-solve-problems/>

Mind Tools. (n.d.). *Root cause analysis: Tracing a problem to its origins*. Mind Tools. Retrieved from http://www.mindtools.com/pages/article/newTMC_80.htm

Warrell, M. (2013, April 22). Why getting comfortable with discomfort is crucial to success. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/margiewarrell/2013/04/22/is-comfort-holding-you-back/>

Zwilling, M. (2011, July 19). *Nine steps to effective business problem solving*. Business Insider. Retrieved from <http://www.businessinsider.com/nine-steps-to-effective-business-problem-solving-2011-7>

Recommended search terms

If you'd like to explore Nimble learning further, try searching online using the following terms:

- Defining the problem.
- Embracing ambiguity.
- Finding and generalizing patterns.
- Learning from past mistakes.
- Overcoming a fear of failure.
- Personal reflection.



More help...

Go to www.kornferry.com/fyi-resources and link directly to the deep dive resources in this chapter. Visit the site often to see the additional resources that are uploaded on a regular basis.



23. ORGANIZATIONAL SAVVY

Maneuvering comfortably through complex policy, process, and people-related organizational dynamics.

Organizations are made up of formal structure, policies, buildings, inventory, intellectual property, and so forth. They may be logically planned and brilliantly orchestrated, but while human beings are still at the core, things can get messy. It's the human element that interjects politics, emotion, uncertainty, intrigue, and conflict. Often, we end up dealing with a confusing blend of the rational and irrational, the controlled and the random, the spoken and the unsaid. It's easy to get lost in the fog. Organizational savvy is the compass that guides you swiftly and without mishap to your destination. People who do this well understand the difference between what the organization intends to be versus the reality. They read the unwritten signs to navigate the organizational maze. They know who has power and influence. They appreciate who has respect. And they are aware of who only has a title. They know which messages work and which ones don't. They use their understanding to move things forward for the greater good. In short, they're masters at getting work done in an organizational setting. So accept the complexity of your organization. Don't fight it. Learn how to work with it to your advantage.



"One of the penalties for refusing to participate in politics is that you end up being governed by your inferiors."

Plato – Greek philosopher

Organizational savvy is in the **People** factor (III) in the Korn Ferry Leadership Architect™. It is part of Cluster I, **Influencing people**, along with *Communicates effectively* (7), *Drives engagement* (16), *Persuades* (24), and *Drives vision and purpose* (37). You may find it helpful to also take a look at some of the tips included in those chapters to supplement your learning.

Skilled

- ★ **Is sensitive to how people and organizations function.**
- ★ **Anticipates land mines and plans approach accordingly.**
- ★ **Deals comfortably with organizational politics.**
- ★ **Knows who has power, respect, and influence.**
- ★ **Steers through the organizational maze to get things done.**

Less skilled

- Overlooks or disregards the political complexities of the organization.
- Pursues own area's goals without considering the impact on other groups.
- Says and does things that strain organizational relationships.
- Tends to be impatient with organizational processes and makes political errors.

Talented

- Navigates the political complexities of the organization easily.
- Has a clear understanding of other groups' business priorities.
- Avoids provoking tension between groups.
- Uses knowledge of organizational culture to achieve objectives.

Overused skill

- May prioritize organizational positioning, even when straightforward action is called for.
- May be seen as excessively political.
- May tell others what they want to hear instead of what he/she knows to be true.

Some possible causes of lower skill

Causes help explain *why* a person may have trouble with Organizational savvy. When seeking to increase skill, it's helpful to consider how these might play out in certain situations. And remember that all of these can be addressed if you are motivated to do so.

- Ignores or denies the reality of the system.
- Inexperienced.
- Resists the reality of complexity.
- Weak negotiator.
- Rejects the need to "play politics."
- Doesn't read others or their interests well.
- Excessively direct and straightforward.
- Lacks influence.
- Low ambiguity tolerance.
- Cynical.



Culture card

Organizational savvy in the United States may be organizational taboo in Japan. Individual versus collective orientation drives a variety of these differences. In the US, there is strong emphasis on contribution of the individual. In Japan, while individual achievements matter, the greater focus is on the whole group succeeding. Without this collective success, individual contribution is meaningless. Self-promotion and celebration of individual accomplishments are accepted and expected in a US business environment. Assertiveness, too, while often applauded in the US, can be perceived as aggression in Japan. Expressing views contrary to the rest of the team isn't common practice in a Japanese business environment. Deciding the most appropriate way to maneuver through the organization requires cultural savvy, especially in the global community.

Tips to develop Organizational savvy

1. **Frustrated? Consider the nature of the organization.** Do you always want to think things are simpler than they are? Sometimes the problem is underestimating the complexity of organizations. While it's possible that some organizations are simple, most are not. Understanding how organizations function takes some discipline. Accept this. Look beyond the obvious to see what's really in the background. Take time to identify both the formal and informal structures that exist in the organization. Notice how they work. The intricacies of both. Use what you learn to facilitate more efficient ways of getting things done.
2. **Lost in the fog? Sharpen your focus.** Proactively navigate your social environment at work. Be an astute observer of others. Look below the surface. See beyond the behavior being displayed and learn to notice the motivation driving the behavior. Observe people. In meetings. During formal and informal conversations. Notice patterns of power and deference. Where do alliances and power coalitions exist? Who do people go to for advice? Who seems to know what's going on? Who shares new insights, information, and news? Noticing these small but significant things will help you build a picture of the informal networks that exist. When you know where these networks are, you can join them.
3. **Outmaneuvered? Learn to read the political landscape.** The political landscape is often viewed as the "dark side" of the organization. Navigating it isn't easy, but it is necessary if you are going to operate effectively. Start by viewing organizational politics as something neutral. As a necessary part of how the

organization functions. As the system through which power and influence is applied and distributed. Be bold in the way you maneuver through it. Take time to diagnose the paths, turns, dead-ends, and zigzags that might exist. Be prepared to take a wrong turn now and then. Reflect on what you learn from your successes and failures along the way. People who are politically savvy know the organization. They know how to get things done.

4. **Don't know the movers and shakers? Identify the key players and their roles.** How do they get things done? Who do they rely on for expediting things through the maze? How do you compare to them? Who are the major gatekeepers who control the flow of resources, information, and decisions? Who are the guides and the helpers? Get to know them better. Build or join coalitions. Who are the major resisters and stoppers? Try to avoid them. Go around them if you have to.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Bergstrand, J. (2013, March 27). Great CIOs are politically savvy. *CIO*.

Bryan, L. L., Matson, E., & Weiss, L. M. (2007, November).

Harnessing the power of informal employee networks.

McKinsey Quarterly.

Goldsmith, M., & Katzenbach, J. (2007, February 14). Navigating the "informal" organization. *Bloomberg Businessweek*.

5. **Right audience, wrong message? Understand what makes individuals and groups distinct.** Become people sensitive. Learn to read people. Predict how they are going to react to you and to what you are trying to get done. Some studies argue that your ability to identify with others is a critical success factor in getting

things done. The magic and the complexity of life is that people are different. Each requires special consideration and treatment. Take time to observe others. How do they react to people and situations? If you are able to predict what individuals or groups will do, you will be able to select from among your various tactics, skills, tones, and styles to get done what you need.

6. **Getting a poor response from others? Make a positive impression.** Personal style can get in the way. People differ in the impression they leave. Study the individual or group you need to influence. What do they value? What would impress them? What steps can you take to achieve this? Research shows that if you are to influence successfully, others need to be positively impressed by your integrity, authenticity, and sincerity. They must see that you are genuine, honest, and forthright. Do this well and you will inspire trust and confidence. As a result, you will achieve more than those who leave a negative impression.
7. **Taking more than you're giving? Think equity.** Relationships that work are built on equity and considering the impact on others. Don't just ask for things; find some common ground where you can provide help, not just ask for it. What does the unit you're contacting need in the way of problem solving or information? Do you know how they see the issue? Is it even important to them? How does what you're working on affect them? If it affects them negatively, can you trade something, appeal to the common good, figure out some way to minimize the work or other impact (volunteering staff help, for example)?
8. **Too agreeable? Balance being agreeable with being political.** Do you value harmony and getting along with others over

getting things done? Are you quick to compromise your interests? Do you tend to be compassionate, cooperative, and considerate toward others? Your accommodating nature alone will not always be enough to drive results. Some circumstances will require you to behave politically. To be more assertive. More competitive. Studies have shown that individuals who combine a highly agreeable approach with high political skill demonstrate higher levels of job performance than those who display low levels of either or both.

9. **Others not coming through for you? Consider your sources of help.** Sometimes the problem is in assessing people. Who really wants to help? Who is going to get in the way? What do they really want? What price will they ask for helping? People are more likely to come through when ideas and suggestions match their needs and fit into their view of the world. Are in line with their values, principles, beliefs, and opinions. Notice what's important to those around you. Check with others who know them well. Use what you learn to target the right sources of help and to position your request in the most influential way for them and their needs.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Deutschman, A. (September 18, 2009). How authentic leaders 'walk the walk.' *Bloomberg Businessweek*.

Fried, J. (2010, November). Jason Fried: Why work doesn't happen at work [Video file]. TED.

Warrell, M. (2013, August 20). Are you too agreeable? 7 Strategies to push back without coming off pushy. *Forbes*.

10. Lost in the maze? Go with the flow. Some people know the steps necessary to get things done but are too impatient to allow events to run their course. Maneuvering through the maze includes stopping once in a while to let things happen. It may mean waiting until a major gatekeeper has the time to pay attention to your needs. Be patient.

11. Thrown off track? Expect the unexpected. Always have a plan of attack but also have a contingency plan. Be ready for instant change. What's the worst that could happen and what will you do? People who are organizationally savvy are personally flexible. They anticipate that things can and will go wrong, but balance this with a can-do attitude and a Plan B up their sleeve. So, faced with a surprise, take a step back. Consider your options. Call on your resources. Accept that things have changed and adjust your course to stay on the right route.

12. Playing the blame game? Keep political conflicts small and concrete. The more abstract it gets, the more unmanageable it becomes. Separate the people from the problem. Attack problems by looking at the nature of the problem, not the person presenting the problem. Avoid direct blaming remarks; describe

the problem and its impact. Focus on finding the shared meaning and conclusion to be drawn from the situation. Find a collaborative solution. If you can't agree on a solution, agree on procedure, or agree on a few things, and list all the issues remaining. This creates some motion and breaks political stalemates.

13. Struggling to find the right approach? Find a mentor. Seek out someone who has a long tenure of success in your organization. Someone whose behavior and style you'd like to emulate. Pay special attention to how they accomplish their work. Let the mentor know that you're especially interested in the process of work—how things "best get done around here." Experiment with new approaches based on what you see and hear from them. Keep a log of what worked and what didn't.

14. Not sure why you're having difficulty? Get some feedback. Often, we're unaware of the obstacles we create for ourselves. For instance, being too assertive or too submissive in different contexts. It is difficult to pull back and monitor, especially in emotionally charged situations. Those who work closest with you are best equipped to tell you how you're doing. Do they perceive you as organizationally savvy, politically aware and agile? Ask at least one person from each group you work with for feedback. Give yourself some honest feedback too. What do you think is blocking you from getting things done smoothly and effectively in the organization?

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Brim, B. (2006, February 9). The best way to influence others. *Gallup Business Journal*.

Marcus, B. (2012, September 5). Hate politics? You still need to be political to advance your career. *Forbes*.

Musselwhite, C. (2007, October 1). Self-awareness and the effective leader. *Inc.*

Job assignments

- Relaunch an existing product or service that's not doing well. Investigate why it's not successful. Identify what is needed for it to be successful.
- Work on a team looking at a reorganization plan. Work on fully understanding where the organization is headed. Do your homework on the organization, including any strategic planning or vision statements to help inform the organizational structure.
- Conduct a postmortem on a failed project and present the findings to the people involved. Involve them in discussions about how things will need to be approached differently next time.
- Write a proposal for a new policy, process, mission, charter, product, service, or system and sell it to management. Anticipate the challenges and questions they will have and be prepared to handle these.
- Volunteer to find a way of bringing together and/or aligning processes, systems, or procedures from across a range of business units.

Take time to reflect...

If you think formal channels are the only route to get things done...

...then ask whether the path less traveled can bring you to a more rewarding destination. Looking behind the scenes can introduce you to information and ideas you didn't even know existed.

If you're baffled by the maze of organizational politics...

...then take a step back to see connections. To understand how things work and why they sometimes don't. Listen. Observe. Analyze. Learn.

If you don't take time to understand what's going on around you...

...then recognize that you could be making your job a lot harder for yourself. Knowing who's who and what's what can help you make a far more valuable contribution to the organization.

"The closer I watch politics, the more it looks like professional wrestling in business suits."

Bosley Gravel – American author



Learn more about Organizational savvy

Barnes, B. K. (2007). *Exercising influence: A guide for making things happen at work, at home, and in your community*. San Francisco, CA: Pfeiffer.

Brandon, R., & Seldman, M. (2004). *Survival of the savvy: High-integrity political tactics for career and company success*. New York, NY: Free Press.

George, B., & Sims, P. (2007). *True north: Discover your authentic leadership*. San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass.

Katzenbach, J. R., & Khan, Z. (2010). *Leading outside the lines: How to mobilize the (in)formal organization, energize your team, and get better results*. San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass.

Showkeir, J., & Showkeir, M. (2008). *Authentic conversations: Moving from manipulation to truth and commitment*. San Francisco, CA: Berrett-Koehler Publishers.



Deep dive learning resource links

Bergstrand, J. (2013, March 27). Great CIOs are politically savvy. *CIO*. Retrieved from http://www.cio.com/article/730538/Great_CIOs_Are_Politically_Savvy

Brim, B. (2006, February 9). The best way to influence others. *Gallup Business Journal*. Retrieved from <http://businessjournal.gallup.com/content/21325/best-way-influence-others.aspx>

Bryan, L. L., Matson, E., & Weiss, L. M. (2007, November). Harnessing the power of informal employee networks. *McKinsey Quarterly*. Retrieved from http://www.mckinsey.com/insights/organization/harnessing_the_power_of_informal_employee_networks

Deutschman, A. (September 18, 2009). How authentic leaders 'walk the walk.' *Bloomberg Businessweek*. Retrieved from <http://>

www.businessweek.com/managing/content/sep2009/ca20090918_716655.htm

Fried, J. (2010, November). Jason Fried: Why work doesn't happen at work [Video file]. TED. Retrieved from http://www.ted.com/talks/jason_fried_why_work_doesn_t_happen_at_work.html

Goldsmith, M., & Katzenbach, J. (2007, February 14). Navigating the "informal" organization. *Bloomberg Businessweek*. Retrieved from <http://www.businessweek.com/stories/2007-02-14/navigating-the-informal-organizationbusinessweek-business-news-stock-market-and-financial-advice>

Marcus, B. (2012, September 5). Hate politics? You still need to be political to advance your career. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/bonniemarcus/2012/09/05/hate-politics-you-still-need-to-be-political-to-advance-your-career/>

Musselwhite, C. (2007, October 1). Self-awareness and the effective leader. *Inc.* Retrieved from <http://www.inc.com/resources/leadership/articles/20071001/musselwhite.html>

Warrell, M. (2013, August 20). Are you too agreeable? 7 Strategies to push back without coming off pushy. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/margiewarrell/2013/08/20/are-you-too-agreeable-7-strategies-to-push-back-without-coming-off-pushy/>

Recommended search terms

If you'd like to explore Organizational savvy further, try searching online using the following terms:

- Authentic leadership.
- Becoming politically savvy.

- Influencing others at work.
- Navigating informal organizations.
- Seeking feedback at work.
- Separating the people from the problem.



More help...

Go to www.kornferry.com/fyi-resources and link directly to the deep dive resources in this chapter. Visit the site often to see the additional resources that are uploaded on a regular basis.



24. PERSUADES

Using compelling arguments to gain the support and commitment of others.

Work gets done through relationships. Sometimes it can be hard to make things happen unless people are persuaded to adapt their point of view and take action. Effective persuasion requires skillful delivery of a message and adjusting to the audience. An emotional connection with others needs to be formed while offering compelling, logical arguments, including data to support viewpoints. Persuasion requires adhering firmly to ideas with strength of resolve, but also knowing when to yield to another's point of view. Sometimes tough-minded individuals need to be persuaded. Groups of people may need to be influenced to think in a different way. One-to-one or one-to-many, persuading can be challenging. But handled effectively, it may change a small part of a project or completely alter the strategic direction of an organization. Whether you simply want to be more effective in your daily relationships through winning hearts and minds, or you need to influence senior stakeholders' decisions, there's a great deal at stake. Learn to be inspiring, motivating, and compelling.



"Let him who would be moved to convince others, be first moved to convince himself."

Thomas Carlyle – Scottish philosopher, writer, teacher, and historian

Persuades is in the **People** factor (III) in the Korn Ferry Leadership Architect™. It is part of Cluster I, **Influencing people**, along with Communicates effectively (7), *Drives* engagement (16), Organizational savvy (23), and *Drives* vision and purpose (37). You may find it helpful to also take a look at some of the tips included in those chapters to supplement your learning.

Skilled

- ★ **Positions views and arguments appropriately to win support.**
- ★ **Convinces others to take action.**
- ★ **Negotiates skillfully in tough situations.**
- ★ **Wins concessions without damaging relationships.**
- ★ **Responds effectively to the reactions and positions of others.**

Less skilled

- Pushes own point of view too strongly.
- Fails to win support or buy-in from others.
- Is unable to negotiate solutions that are agreeable to all.
- Responds negatively to the reactions and positions of others.
- Has difficulty articulating a logical argument that supports own position

Talented

- Shares own ideas in a compelling manner that gains commitment from others.
- Negotiates skillfully and creates minimal noise when working toward an agreed-upon solution.
- Finds common ground and acceptable alternatives that satisfy the needs of multiple stakeholders.

Overused skill

- Attempts to negotiate when the situation calls for tough and decisive action.
- Spends so much time persuading that timely results are missed.
- May come across as manipulative.

Some possible causes of lower skill

Causes help explain *why* a person may have trouble with Persuades. When seeking to increase skill, it's helpful to consider how these might play out in certain situations. And remember that all of these can be addressed if you are motivated to do so.

- Low personal confidence.
- Lacks allies or supporters.
- No credibility.
- Not confident in ideas.
- Comes on too strong.
- Does not listen or respond to objections.
- No plan for action or follow-up.
- Does not have a clear purpose and vision.

- Poor presentation skills.
- Too easily discouraged.



Brain booster

It seems common sense that the most successful persuaders are those who have a genuine passion for their ideas. But it's not just logic that suggests this to be the case; this is also supported by neuroscience. When someone successfully influences another person, neural regions related to the brain's reward system are highly activated. This tells us the influencer feels positive about the idea. Genuinely believes in it. We also know that successful persuasion involves the influencer going a step further than this by putting themselves in the shoes of the person they're trying to persuade. They imagine the value of the idea to the other person. How does brain function substantiate this? The other area of the brain activated during effective persuasion includes the neural network that relates to perspective-taking or imagining the views of others. So, before you try to persuade, get your own house in order first. If you don't have passion, find it. If you don't see the benefits to others, figure them out. And don't try to fake it. We also know that brain activities of message recipients mirror those of the communicator. If you don't believe, then most likely, neither will they.

Tips to develop Persuades

1. **Need to be heard? Speak up.** Ever proposed a great idea only to see it die? Then someone else stole your thunder with the same idea? Did it feel like a conspiracy? The fault may lie with you. Perhaps you hung back at a critical moment. Maybe you

were too polite to get out in front. Too modest and quiet. If you hesitate to put a stake in the ground, someone with fewer inhibitions will beat you to it. Learn to step into the spotlight. Lean into the conversation. Celebrate the cause. Push yourself to speak up in meetings. Call meetings of your own and build enthusiasm. Look for opportunities to establish yourself as an expert on certain topics. Put together a session and invite colleagues to tap into your knowledge. Share links that support your point of view. Write an article or blog on the topic. If you're uncomfortable claiming the spotlight, remember this is not about you but about the value of your ideas.

2. No allies? Build relationships first. Persuaders have a good reputation that precedes them. They find like-minded allies. They perform at a high level, turn in results, keep their promises, and reach out to help others. They build rapport and trust. Their ideas get implemented because they know people, and people know them. If you doubt this, try asking someone you don't know to join you for lunch. Notice how hard it is to convince them to spend time with you. Even before you have a need, build relationships. Reach out across the organization. Be curious. Tear yourself away from your e-mail, get up from your desk, walk down the hall. Visit other offices. Arrive early to meetings, introduce yourself, and find common ground. Follow up on a teleconference with a personal call to someone you'd like to know better. Learn about other functions. Find out who people are, what interests them, what concerns them, and how they are motivated. Get behind their ideas and you can better persuade them to get behind yours.

3. Need more help? Start with your boss. If you're very independent or reluctant to ask your boss for help, this is a good time to practice new behaviors. Sometimes you are empowered to lead the charge. But sometimes you need the support of your boss or someone else in the upper echelon. Set up the meeting. Then be sure you are prepared with the full picture, including what you want to do and what kind of support you need. Recognize that your boss has a network of relationships and responsibilities and that your request for support may align with other initiatives already underway. Or it may clash. There may be competition for scarce resources. Ask for your boss's perspective and advice on how you can and should proceed. If you get the go-ahead and/or an offer of support, plan the next steps.

4. Lack confidence? Address root causes. Not sure how your ideas will be received? Intimidated when you have to persuade your boss of something? Worried about working in a part of the world you've never experienced before? Everyone can lose confidence under certain circumstances. A little anxiety is normal. But successful people don't let it hold them back. When you're losing confidence, start by noticing exactly what makes you anxious. Then do something to address the problem. If you're not sure of your basic ideas, run a pilot. Get input, ask questions, search for examples of what has been tried and proven. If asking for your boss's support makes you tongue-tied, try thinking of them as a customer who needs what you have to offer. Going to a new country? Get information. Go online, get a guidebook, talk to someone who has been there. Build your confidence and you will build your skill in persuading. And when you really need courage,

contemplate Eleanor Roosevelt's assertion: "You must do the thing you think you cannot do."

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Blalock, B. (2013, October 15). 10 Steps to executive-level confidence. *The Wall Street Journal*.

Michaels, S. (2011, August 22). 3 Powerful skills you must have to succeed in sales. *Forbes*.

5. **Ahead of the crowd? Explain your thinking.** You may be a trend-spotter. An intuitive decision maker. A conceptual thinker, comfortable with ambiguity. You can leap to conclusions or set direction without much data. If so, congratulations! Your agile thinking is needed. But to be credible, you need to let others in on the secrets. Tell them what information underlies your idea. They need to relate to it. See the rationale. Understand what inspired you. Can you show others how your vision will help the business perform better? Describe how it will keep your organization ahead of the competition. Search for like-minded people who support your thinking. Use data from emerging demographics, leading-edge product ideas, or industry best practices to bolster your credibility. Explain how your credentials and experience qualify you as an expert. Share stories of past success. Build a prototype to show how this could work. Speak in the language of your audience. Fill in the dots. Use data if others need it, even if you don't.
6. **Poor presenter? Get some training—and relax.** Giving a presentation is the greatest human fear, after dying. To reduce your fear of presenting, eliminate the need to be perfect and

instead aim for being practiced, confident, and engaging. Great presenters are human. They are comfortable because they know they are imperfect. Unfazed by glitches. Familiar with their material. Connected with the audience. Prepared but not robotic. Be eager to share your thoughts. Dress well but comfortably. Breathe and smile. Acquaint yourself with the technology and don't get flustered when it acts up—as it often does. Your audience is not a panel of judges scoring your performance, but interested learners who are on your side. Observe presenters whose style you admire. How do they keep themselves comfortable and the audience engaged? Browse YouTube to see what works and what doesn't. Watch the movie *The King's Speech* to learn how George VI worked toward overcoming his fear. Hire a presentation or media coach to help you get comfortable on a stage, behind a podium, and on the screen.

7. **Can't get others to see what you see? Draw the complete picture.** "Trust me" is not enough to win over busy people. When things are about to change, people want the full picture. They need to see the vision and the process for getting there. To know not only *what* the end game is, but *how* it will happen. *Why* is it happening. And what is needed from them. Be honest about what you want them to do. Be clear on how they will benefit. Share initial process plans. Be prepared to literally draw pictures. Show them a path toward completion, then work with them to build the roadway.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

DeGideo, A. (2009, July 7). *Communication keys: 7 Steps to more compelling arguments*. Business Brief.

Gallo, A. (2010, November 15). How to get your idea approved. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*.

- 8. Can't engage the team? Give them a challenge.** Persuaders don't have all the answers. But they do ask great questions. In the book *Hot Spots*, author Lynda Gratton writes that one way to motivate teams is to ask a challenging question that inspires purposeful action. When the CEO of BP asked "How can a large oil company become a creator of value in the world?" the teams at BP created significant investments in alternative energy. Ask: What if...? How can we...? What else...? Igniting questions catalyze change. Get the best from yourself and others. In every endeavor, ask, "How can we do this better?"
- 9. Getting resistance? Establish common ground.** Seeing a lot of folded arms in meetings? Getting the silent treatment when it's time for questions in the town hall? Negotiations at a standstill? Some people need lots of information to be convinced—especially when the stakes are high. When you are at an impasse, stop the meeting and go back to basic causes. Tell them why this agreement is important to you and ask what is important to them. Identify what you each need and ask how you can get it. Skeptics are more likely to get on board if they understand that you care about what they care about. Like customers. Or financial clarity. Or plant safety. Or the company's reputation for great products. Disclose your own intentions and stay open to others' deepest

values. Have an honest conversation about why you are there. You will build a sense of trust and shared purpose that brings people together.

- 10. Hearing emotional objections? Use empathy with sound thinking.** People getting emotional about a proposed change? You might want to try to leave emotion out of it and move immediately to action. But that's like trying to rearrange the furniture while the room is on fire. Emotion is powerful. Until it is dealt with, it can derail any initiative. To win over groups or individuals, you must first empathize with them. See it from their point of view. Understand and acknowledge emotional objections. Allow time for emotional venting and conversation. Only then—when emotions have calmed—can you move to the logical side of the equation. Douse the fire first—by listening. Then use good thinking to show the objective soundness of your ideas. Come to an understanding that will work for all parties.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Moss Kanter, R. (2012, September 25). Ten reasons people resist change. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*.

Quast, L. (2012, November 26). Overcome the 5 main reasons people resist change. *Forbes*.

- 11. Seen as stubborn or rigid? Get input early and often.** You have great ideas. So do your colleagues, managers, customers, vendors, and team members. Persuasive people are clear on overall objectives and impact. And they are curious about others' reactions and open to new thinking. If you're too rigid in your beliefs or exert too much control over the process, creative and

potentially interested people will drop by the wayside. Hold brainstorming sessions or work with a few colleagues to get good ideas on the table. Seek people's input at the creation phase. What are their views? What concerns do they have? What can they add? Allow course corrections and creative refinements in the execution phase. People are more likely to come round to your way of thinking if they feel they've had the chance to contribute to its shaping.

12. Getting worked up? Pause to regroup. Passionate? Frustrated? Convinced that you have the answer? Want to do it now? It's easy to come on too strong. Especially if you're getting attacked, being rejected, or not feeling heard. But raised voices and frustration only drive people away. If you're heated in meetings or tempted to fire off an e-mail you'll regret, take a break. Sit down and figure out what has you so upset. Process all of your hurt feelings and personal emotions. Did something like this happen to you when you were younger and you still feel the pain? Let it go. List all of the reasons why something seems like a great idea. Then list all of the reasons why others might not be so enthusiastic. Face facts until you see things clearly. Remember, this is not about you but about the value of the idea. When you are emotionally calm and thinking clearly, make a strategic decision about whether to proceed and, if you do, how to go about it. Resolve to try a new and more inclusive approach. Engage a friend or coach to help you understand how others see you and how you can behave differently.

13. Have positional power? Use it wisely. As the saying goes, "Power corrupts." But we expect our leaders to be decisive,

optimistic, in charge, and making things happen. Good leaders are comfortable using positional and functional power for the right reasons. When you want to change others' behavior, reassess the tools and resources at your disposal. Sales executive? Sales contests create healthy competition that drives action. CEO or HR leader? Compensation structures reward performance. Virtual team leader? Face-to-face meetings build morale. Sometimes a title alone can persuade others to follow your lead, at least in the short-term. Inhabit your role as executive, expert, team manager, member of the leadership team. Step lightly but firmly. Proceed with respect and integrity. You are here for a reason.

14. Situation stalled? Don't quit yet. Persuasion is rarely a one-time event. Life changes. Situations are fluid. Needs shift over time. Persuasive people are both flexible and determined. They know what's negotiable and where the line is drawn. What they can concede and what they need to hold on to. When to walk away and when to return. They process situations and find a way to bounce back. If you encounter "no" or indifference, don't quit. "No" might mean "not now" or "I need to think about this some more." Ask what is needed to get to "yes." Will time, more information, or the support of your peers get the negotiation back on track? Do you need to give in order to get? Be firm but be resilient. Use respectful persistence. Plan some follow-up tactics. Get perspective and be patient. You may be in this for the long haul. Don't give up until you have decided that a different idea is the way forward.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Goulston, M., & Ullmen, J. (2013, March 19). For real influence, listen past your blind spots. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*.

Hall, J. (2013, June 19). Don't let your ego grow bigger than your influence. *Forbes*.

Job assignments

- Lead or participate in a change initiative, such as a business integration, that requires people from different organizations to create a new structure.
- Volunteer to represent your organization as the keynote speaker or expert panelist at an upcoming industry conference.
- Invite the most skeptical member of your peer group to partner with you on a change initiative. Get to the root of their resistance and help them understand the importance of the change.
- Create and lead a webinar discussion on the value of self-awareness in persuasive leaders. Create a compelling session that will engage your audience.
- Handle a tough negotiation with an internal or external client or customer. Beforehand, find out as much as you can about them and try to understand the situation from their viewpoint.

Take time to reflect...

If you have good ideas that no one seems to want to hear about...

...then realize that a strong idea requires a strong case behind it. Delivering compelling evidence and capturing people's imaginations can help ensure a win.

If you're frustrated by the endless debates that simple changes require...

...then reconcile yourself with the need to be persistent. Your strength of resolve will pay dividends in the long run and get you the results you're looking for.

If you find relating to others tough and a chore...

...then recognize the importance of people feeling connected in order to accept a point of view. It's easier for them to buy into your idea if they buy into you.

"The key to successful leadership today is influence, not authority."

Ken Blanchard – American author and management expert



Learn more about Persuades

Bacon, T. R. (2011). *Elements of influence: The art of getting others to follow your lead*. New York, NY: AMACOM.

George, B., & Sims, P. (2007). *True north: Discover your authentic leadership*. San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass.

Goulston, M., & Ullmen, J. (2013). *Real influence: Persuade without pushing and gain without giving in*. New York, NY: AMACOM.

Mortensen, K. W. (2013). *Maximum influence: The 12 universal laws of power persuasion* (2nd ed.). New York, NY: AMACOM.

Scharlatt, H., & Smith, R. (2011). *Influence: Gaining commitment, getting results* (2nd ed.). Greensboro, NC: Center for Creative Leadership.



Deep dive learning resource links

Blalock, B. (2013, October 15). 10 Steps to executive-level confidence. *The Wall Street Journal*. Retrieved from <http://blogs.wsj.com/speakeasy/2013/10/15/10-steps-to-executive-level-confidence/>

DeGideo, A. (2009, July 7). *Communication keys: 7 Steps to more compelling arguments*. Business Brief. Retrieved from <http://www.businessbrief.com/communication-keys-7-steps-to-more-compelling-arguments/>

Gallo, A. (2010, November 15). How to get your idea approved. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*. Retrieved from <http://blogs.hbr.org/2010/11/how-to-get-their-approval/>

Goulston, M., & Ullmen, J. (2013, March 19). For real influence, listen past your blind spots. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*. Retrieved from <http://blogs.hbr.org/2013/03/for-real-influence-use-level-f/>

Hall, J. (2013, June 19). Don't let your ego grow bigger than your influence. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/johnhall/2013/06/19/dont-let-your-ego-grow-bigger-than-your-influence/>

Michaels, S. (2011, August 22). 3 Powerful skills you must have to succeed in sales. *Forbes*. Retrieved from [http://www.forbes.com/](http://www.forbes.com/sites/womensmedia/2011/08/22/3-powerful-skills-you-must-have-to-succeed-in-sales/)

[sites/womensmedia/2011/08/22/3-powerful-skills-you-must-have-to-succeed-in-sales/](http://www.forbes.com/sites/womensmedia/2011/08/22/3-powerful-skills-you-must-have-to-succeed-in-sales/)

Moss Kanter, R. (2012, September 25). Ten reasons people resist change. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*. Retrieved from <http://blogs.hbr.org/2012/09/ten-reasons-people-resist-change/>

Quast, L. (2012, November 26). Overcome the 5 main reasons people resist change. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/lisaquast/2012/11/26/overcome-the-5-main-reasons-people-resist-change/>

Recommended search terms

If you'd like to explore Persuades further, try searching online using the following terms:

- Building confidence.
- Building real influence.
- Dealing with resistance to change.
- Making a compelling argument in business.
- Persuading others in business.



More help...

Go to www.kornferry.com/fyi-resources and link directly to the deep dive resources in this chapter. Visit the site often to see the additional resources that are uploaded on a regular basis.



25. PLANS AND ALIGNS

Planning and prioritizing work to meet commitments aligned with organizational goals.

Nothing helps move things along better than a good plan. And a clear marker of a good plan is one that is aligned with strategic priorities. Plans lay a foundation. Aligned plans enable you, your team, and the entire organization to move in the right direction. Plans help people get organized and remain focused. They lead to better use of resources. Reduce scrambling. Help people anticipate problems. And prompt them to proceed with more confidence. This is particularly important given the rapid change and uncertainty prevalent in organizational life. Bob Johansen of the Institute for the Future describes the importance of providing clarity as a smart way to address chaos and confusion. Plans do just that. Instead of jumping into action, use the planning process to deliberate on what you're trying to accomplish. Line up your plans and projects so they are in sync with strategic organizational priorities. Collaborate with others to develop robust, flexible plans that guide you where you want to go.



*"The end we aim at must be known
before the way can be made."*

Jean Paul – German writer

Plans and aligns is in the **Results** factor (II) in the Korn Ferry Leadership Architect™. It is part of Cluster E, **Managing execution**, along with **Directs work** (15) and **Optimizes work processes** (38). You may find it helpful to also take a look at some of the tips included in those chapters to supplement your learning.

Skilled

- ★ **Sets objectives to align with broader organizational goals.**
- ★ **Breaks down objectives into appropriate initiatives and actions.**
- ★ **Stages activities with relevant milestones and schedules.**
- ★ **Anticipates and adjusts effective contingency plans.**

Less skilled

- Gets caught up in immediate needs without attending to larger priorities.
- Spends time and resources without a clear purpose.
- Gets caught off guard by problems due to the lack of contingency plans.
- Haphazardly tracks progress or performance.

Talented

- Focuses on highest priorities and sets aside less critical tasks.
- Lays out a thorough schedule and steps for achieving objectives.
- Makes implementation plans that allocate resources precisely.
- Looks for obstacles and develops excellent contingency plans.
- Uses milestones to diligently track and manage the progress of the work.

Overused skill

- Is so focused on completing only mission-critical tasks that he/she lets the trivial many accumulate into a critical problem.
- Persistently follows plans, allowing little room for change.
- May leave out the human element of the work.
- Spends an inordinate amount of time planning for unlikely obstacles or roadblocks.

Some possible causes of lower skill

Causes help explain *why* a person may have trouble with Plans and aligns. When seeking to increase skill, it's helpful to consider how these might play out in certain situations. And remember that all of these can be addressed if you are motivated to do so.

- Doesn't think ahead.
- Short-term focus.
- Lacks structure; disorganized.
- Avoids communication.
- Impatient.
- Oversimplifies.

- Poor time management.
- Not detail oriented.



Did you know?

In a 2011 survey of 1,500 executives conducted globally, McKinsey & Company found that only 9% of those surveyed were "very satisfied" with how they allocated time. One-third of the respondents were "actively dissatisfied." The survey also explored the degree to which these executives were strategically aligned in terms of the use of their time. Only 52% said the way they spent their time largely matched the strategic priorities of their organization. With nearly half admitting they were not focusing sufficiently on guiding the strategic direction of the business, this shows that the time challenges experienced by executives not only affect them as individuals, but is also likely to impact the well-being of the company.

Tips to develop Plans and aligns

1. Planning without clarity? Define overall goals and objectives.

Before developing a plan, take time to understand its purpose. What exactly needs to be accomplished and why? Is there a problem that needs to be solved? An initiative that needs to be organized? An effort that needs to be managed? Who has identified the need? What's the context? What's at stake? Who will benefit from a successful outcome? What will success look like according to key customers and stakeholders? What criteria will be used to measure success? Defining clear goals and objectives from the beginning is critical to plan effectively and deliver the

desired results. The more specific you are, the less disagreement there will be about whether you have achieved your objectives.

2. Don't know what to include? Lay out the work and tasks. Most successful projects begin with a good plan. Once you've identified the objectives, outline the scope, desired outcomes, and key measures. What skills are needed to accomplish the goals? Who should be on the team? What additional resources are required? Then create a schedule using the appropriate level of detail for the project team, sponsors, and stakeholders. A high-level overview typically includes phases, milestones, and key deliverables set to a time line. A detailed plan adds all the steps from A to Z. Take special care outlining these steps—many people are perceived as lacking planning skills because they leave important things out. Consider starting at the end or from a deadline, working backward from Z to A when mapping out the steps. Laying out tasks in reverse order can help you develop a realistic schedule. Ask others for feedback on the plans and incorporate their input.

3. Want more structure? Use planning tools and software. Become an expert on frameworks and tools to create flowcharts, visualize plans, and monitor progress. A Work Breakdown Structure (WBS) prompts you to subdivide activities into the smallest possible task. For each task, ask, "What has to be done in order to accomplish this?" until nothing else can be subdivided. Estimate the duration and resources needed for each task. A Critical Path diagram shows all essential activities needed to complete the project, plus the total time it will take. The activities should be in the right order. Some must be sequential—

they depend on others being completed first. Other activities can happen concurrently or in parallel. There are two other widely used flowcharting tools that show time lines, sequences, and dependencies. Gantt charts are a bar-type visual for smaller projects. A PERT diagram is used for more complex projects, often as a monitoring tool. Share the output of the various tools with others so everyone stays up-to-date and can see when a plan is off track. Select software that meets your needs but isn't too difficult to learn. Find someone to train you and to share frequently used templates so you don't have to reinvent the wheel.

4. Limited resources? Obtain and manage resources wisely. Nothing stalls the execution of a plan like lack of resources. Think through what you'll need for each phase and activity of your plan. People, funding, tools, technology, space, materials. Which resources can you obtain easily and control on your own? Which do you need to locate, negotiate for, or get help securing? Present a clear rationale to decision makers. Outline the difference these resources will make toward effectively meeting your objectives. How will they impact results? Completion time? Budget? What short- and long-term implications exist? How will other areas of the enterprise be impacted? Explain how you'll allocate the resources efficiently and avoid waste. Describe the risks of not obtaining needed resources. Get creative and be willing to bargain for needed resources. What can you trade with other groups? What can you share? Discuss viable options along with their associated costs/benefits.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

For Dummies. (n.d.). *How to create a work breakdown structure*.

For Dummies: A Wiley Brand.

Larson, E., & Larson, R. (2004, September 10). How to create a clear project plan. *CIO Magazine*.

Mind Tools. (n.d.). *Locke's goal setting theory: Understanding SMART goal setting*. Mind Tools.

Stolovitsky, N. (2012, October 19). *Top 10 tips for effective resource management whether jumping from space or not*. Genius Project.

5. **Unsure how things fit with the big picture? Align your objectives.** It's common sense to align objectives with broader organizational goals. Unfortunately, it's not always common practice. Connecting the strategic dots helps create a common mindset. Reduces confusion. Increases efficiency of effort. Each individual's goals should align with and support the team's objectives. Each team should have goals that align with and support the department's objectives. And so forth on up. Once alignment is clear, you'll have a better sense of what to prioritize in your daily work. With goals as the guide, separate potential actions into four areas: mission critical, important to get done, nice to do if time is left over, and unrelated to the organization's main goals. When choosing what to do, apply the scale and always choose the highest level. Plan and execute what matters most.
6. **Operate in a silo? Engage in collaborative planning.** Research has found that one of the best ways to gain commitment is to ask

people for their ideas—especially when the work is first taking shape. Consult with others from the beginning to build support for the project. Meet with those who will be implementing the plan. Share the overall intent so they understand the context. Work together to map things out and then ask them to review your drafts. Is the sequencing correct? Are the right people involved? Can they commit to this schedule? What gaps exist? Gather their input about the many moving parts. How will outputs from one group relate to the work of other units? Where can you consolidate or streamline tasks to save time and accomplish more? What risks should be addressed? Make sure all team members understand and agree to the plan. Also seek advice from those who have planned or worked on similar projects. What did they learn that could be applied to the current project? Always remember that what you do is part of a broader strategy and interconnected system.

7. **Keeping others in the dark? Communicate plans with stakeholders.** The cooperation and engagement of stakeholders will be crucial to achieving your plan's objectives. Identify your key stakeholders. What are their interests and needs? How much information do they want? What vehicles of communication do they prefer? At what frequency? Develop and follow a communication plan to stay in touch with them. Communicate the overall aims, approach, and time line of your project. Include meaningful milestones, such as when you need their input on decisions or for approvals. Let stakeholders know what's progressing according to plan and what is not. If you anticipate problems or delays, inform those who will be affected as soon as possible and determine workable solutions.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Harding, C. (2010, January 14). *Project status reporting process*. Project Management Online.

Lavoie, A. (n.d.). *Ignoring this issue could ruin your company*. CEO.

Mekšs, D. (2012). *30 Greatest online project management and collaboration tools for easy communication!* 1st Web Designer.

Merrett, R. (2012, July 31). *Want project success? Engage stakeholders*. CIO Magazine.

8. **Not tracking details closely enough? Monitor progress against the plan.** If a leader or stakeholder asks an important question related to the status of your project, could you respond quickly and accurately? Could you estimate time to completion? Provide a budget update? At the outset of the project, develop a system for tracking time lines and measures that are meaningful to team members and stakeholders—cost and quality control, scheduling variances, scope changes, resource usage. When in doubt, return to your objectives. What are you trying to do? Review success criteria regularly—have a dashboard of these metrics within easy reach. Periodically distribute executive summaries to all parties. Supplement the summaries with additional information relevant for specific groups. Give everyone involved in implementing the plan progress reports. When you reach milestones, share updates related to achievements, decisions, potential risks, and next steps.
9. **Not anticipating potential roadblocks? Envision the plan in process.** Take time to picture what could go wrong from the start of the plan to its completion. Discuss potential scenarios with

colleagues who have diverse vantage points. How might things play out? What's the worst-case scenario? What other setbacks or glitches might occur? Rank the potential problems from highest likelihood to lowest likelihood. What will you do if the highest likelihood things happen? Create contingency plans for each. Take steps to prevent problems and monitor warning signs. Pay close attention to the weakest links. These are usually groups or elements you have the least interface with or control over (perhaps someone in a remote location, a consultant or supplier). Stay doubly in touch with the potential weak links. Things can change quickly, so at various milestones, go back through your mental checklist. Anticipate and have Plan B ready.

10. **Overly optimistic when developing plans? Plan for the unplanned.** Many use "best-case scenario" formulas when making initial plans. They're eager to please the customer. To deliver top-quality results quickly and affordably. Stretch goals are admirable. But overpromising isn't practical or smart—it can lead to execution problems and fallout from unmet expectations. It can also make the planner seem naive. Strive to make your plans realistic. Get input from others experienced with similar projects. Take into account challenges that are likely to crop up. When dealing with unknowns, give yourself time to become familiar with the territory. There are human and unforeseen aspects related to every plan. Anticipate challenges without letting them overwhelm you. Adapt the plan in light of new insights.
11. **Prefer plans to stay the same? Be ready to adapt and act.** Are you naturally wired to want to finalize plans and move on? Think revisiting plans is a waste of time? Given how frequently plans are

launched in dynamic and unpredictable environments, changes should be expected. Even welcomed. Change can mean that people are paying close attention to evolving information. It can signal that they're discovering new opportunities for innovation. If you or your organization values innovation and entrepreneurial zeal, you may want to reassess how you approach planning. An overemphasis on plans can slow things down. Research conducted by Saras Sarasvathy at the Darden School of Business indicates that many entrepreneurs begin with action rather than planning. They take "smart steps," evaluate what is learned, then build on it to pursue their goals. Traditional organizations often fear that a lack of planning will increase risk. The entrepreneurs studied believe that risk is actually reduced, given the real-world data they obtain during a series of quick, inexpensive steps.

12. Changes getting out of hand? Beware of scope creep. An important aspect of planning is managing scope. Scope creep occurs when stakeholders' expectations have expanded, but the changes have not been vetted and time lines and resources have not been adjusted to accommodate. It could stem from customer requests, unforeseen complications, cost overruns, resource constraints, scheduling adjustments. Whatever the case, scope creep results in additional work. If not identified and managed properly, the plan could get behind schedule, run over budget, or not meet agreed-upon objectives. Guard against pressure to deliver more than was originally planned without going through a proper revision process. Establish standard change procedures and make sure people are aware of them. Typically, this includes a change request form that states the reasons, costs, and sign-offs

needed by project leads and sponsors. Change is inevitable—be ready to manage it.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

- Knight, J., Thomas, R., & Angus, B. (2013, June 4). Battle scope creep in your projects. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*.
- Mochari, I. (2014, January 15). 3 Risks of not tracking your progress. *Inc*.
- Pitagorsky, G. (2011, January 26). Project managers are change managers. *Project Times*.
- Stolovitsky, N. (2010, August 4). *Planning for the unplanned: Including risk in your project management strategy*. Genius Project.
-

Job assignments

- Plan an off-site meeting, conference, convention, or trade show where you'll need to closely monitor the time line leading up to the event.
- Lead a strategic alignment initiative to ensure your team/department/unit goals and plans are integrated with those from other areas, and that all are aligned with broader organizational priorities.
- Take on a project or assignment that requires collaborative planning with colleagues from various disciplines, divisions, or geographies.
- Plan the renovation of an office, floor, building, service center, lab, warehouse, etc., that requires you to carefully manage scope and resources.

- Plan the installation and integration of a new process or system (e.g., IT, HR, finance, procurement), making sure stakeholders remain engaged and updated throughout the process.

Take time to reflect...

If you'd rather improvise than take the time to come up with a plan...

...then consider that there are many destinations you'll never reach without a map. A strong plan allows you to take well-considered steps in new territory. Avoid hazards. Arrive sooner.

If you're spontaneous by nature...

...then recognize the potential pitfalls of doing things without the benefit of forethought. Aligning resources, ideas, and goals requires anticipation and planning. It doesn't happen by accident.

If you're easily unsettled when things go off track...

...then acknowledge that sometimes plans go awry. Obstacles are inevitable, so staying open to a shift in route is pragmatic and realistic. Detours can turn out to be the best part of any trip.

"It is a bad plan that cannot be changed."

Publilius Syrus – Assyrian aphorist



Learn more about Plans and aligns

Chermack, T. J. (2011). *Scenario planning in organizations: How to create, use and assess scenarios*. San Francisco, CA: Berrett-Koehler Publishers.

Kerzner, H. (2005). *Project management: A systems approach to planning, scheduling, and controlling* (9th ed.). Hoboken, NJ: John Wiley & Sons.

Manas, J. (2006). *Napoleon on project management: Timeless lessons in planning, execution, and leadership*. Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson.

Ogilvy, J. A. (2002). *Creating better futures: Scenario planning as a tool for a better tomorrow*. New York, NY: Oxford University Press, Inc.

Tomczyk, C. A. (2005). *Project manager's spotlight on planning*. Alameda, CA: SYBEX, Inc.



Deep dive learning resource links

For Dummies. (n.d.). *How to create a work breakdown structure*. For Dummies: A Wiley Brand. Retrieved from <http://www.dummies.com/how-to/content/how-to-create-a-work-breakdown-structure.html>

Harding, C. (2010, January 14). *Project status reporting process*. Project Management Online. Retrieved from <http://projectmanagementonline.wordpress.com/2010/01/14/project-status-reporting-process/>

Knight, J., Thomas, R., & Angus, B. (2013, June 4). Battle scope creep in your projects. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*. Retrieved from <http://blogs.hbr.org/2013/06/battling-scope-creep-in-your-p/>

Larson, E., & Larson, R. (2004, September 10). How to create a clear project plan. *CIO Magazine*. Retrieved from http://www.cio.com.au/article/166486/how_create_clear_project_plan/

Lavoie, A. (n.d.). *Ignoring this issue could ruin your company*. CEO. Retrieved from http://www.ceo.com/leadership_and_management/ignoring-this-issue-could-ruin-your-company/

Mekšs, D. (2012). *30 Greatest online project management and collaboration tools for easy communication!* 1st Web Designer. Retrieved from <http://www.1stwebdesigner.com/design/project-management-collaboration-tools/>

Merrett, R. (2012, July 31). Want project success? Engage stakeholders. *CIO Magazine*. Retrieved from http://www.cio.com.au/article/432205/want_project_success_engage_stakeholders/

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Mochari, I. (2014, January 15). 3 Risks of not tracking your progress. *Inc.* Retrieved from <http://www.inc.com/ilan-mochari/3-risks-not-tracking.html>

Pitagorsky, G. (2011, January 26). Project managers are change managers. *Project Times*. Retrieved from <http://www.projecttimes.com/george-pitagorsky/project-managers-are-change-managers.html>

Stolovitsky, N. (2010, August 4). *Planning for the unplanned: Including risk in your project management strategy*. Genius Project. Retrieved from <http://www.geniusproject.com/blog/pm-best-practices/planning-for-the-unplanned-including-risk-in-your-project-management-strategy/>

Stolovitsky, N. (2012, October 19). *Top 10 tips for effective resource management whether jumping from space or not*. Genius Project. Retrieved from <http://www.geniusproject.com/blog/famous-projects/top-10-tips-for-effective-resource-management-when-jumping-from-space/>

Recommended search terms

If you'd like to explore Plans and aligns further, try searching online using the following terms:

- Dealing with and preventing scope creep.
- Effectively managing resources.
- Project planning.
- Regular status reporting in project management.
- Setting clear goals.
- Tracking project progress and change.



More help...

Go to www.kornferry.com/fyi-resources and link directly to the deep dive resources in this chapter. Visit the site often to see the additional resources that are uploaded on a regular basis.



26. BEING RESILIENT

Rebounding from setbacks and adversity when facing difficult situations.

Setbacks are often unavoidable. Potential pitfalls are everywhere, especially in today's demanding, adverse, and often volatile working environment. Even the most resilient people experience setbacks. The difference is they anticipate them. Meet them head-on. Have the ability to withstand them. They use their resilience to stay in control. To keep positive and believe there is a way forward, even when it can't be seen. They recover quickly, learn, and move forward. But resilience doesn't come easy. It requires courage and commitment. But without it, stress can rise to unmanageable levels. Performance can fall away. You can burn out. The more resilient you become, the more you'll stay calm under pressure and positively adapt to difficult situations. You'll keep going when you feel like giving up. You'll bounce back to baseline levels of performance, confidence, and satisfaction sooner. Not only that, you'll be better equipped to confront the next challenge that arises. You'll be stronger.



*"Do not judge me by my successes,
judge me by how many times I fell down
and got back up again."*

Nelson Mandela – South African anti-apartheid revolutionary, politician,
and former president of South Africa

Being resilient is in the **Self** factor (IV) in the Korn Ferry Leadership Architect™. It is part of Cluster L, **Being flexible and adaptable**, along with *Manages ambiguity* (3), *Nimble learning* (22), and *Situational adaptability* (31). You may find it helpful to also take a look at some of the tips included in those chapters to supplement your learning.

Skilled

- ★ **Is confident under pressure.**
- ★ **Handles and manages crises effectively.**
- ★ **Maintains a positive attitude despite adversity.**
- ★ **Bounces back from setbacks.**
- ★ **Grows from hardships and negative experiences.**

Less skilled

- Gets easily rattled in high-pressure situations.
- Exhibits low energy and motivation during times of stress and worry.
- Acts defensively when faced with criticism or roadblocks.
- Takes too long to recover from setbacks.

Talented

- Stays focused and composed in stressful situations.
- Maintains a positive attitude and forward-thinking approach despite troubling circumstances or setbacks.
- Takes constructive action to navigate difficulties or obstacles.
- Is viewed as a source of confidence in high-stress situations.

Overused skill

- Is unreasonably confident and optimistic; could miss the early signs of trouble.
- Fails to show emotion in appropriate circumstances; comes across as cold and uncaring.
- May allow stress to pile up, risking burnout.
- Minimizes the implications or severity of the situation.

Some possible causes of lower skill

Causes help explain *why* a person may have trouble with *Being* resilient. When seeking to increase skill, it's helpful to consider how these might play out in certain situations. And remember that all of these can be addressed if you are motivated to do so.

- Doesn't push hard enough.
- Withdraws when faced with resistance.
- Gives up too soon.
- Lacks composure.
- Takes things personally.
- Won't take charge.
- Lacks belief and passion.

- Freezes when situations change quickly.
- Uncomfortable with rejection.
- Lacks physical/mental fitness.



Brain booster

Losing composure is often an instantaneous reaction that we have not “filtered” through our rational brain. In fact, it's the brain's limbic system that drives the increased heartbeat, flushed face, sweaty palms, and the flash of emotion that accompany a loss of composure. The limbic system is one of the most primitive areas of the brain and it's designed to detect threats of all kinds. A perceived lack of fairness, lack of certainty, or lack of respect are all modern-day threats that our limbic system is attuned to. Once your brain detects a threat and your amygdala (emotional response center) is activated, the prefrontal cortex (PFC), which is responsible for rational thinking, is impaired. In this frame of mind, you are more likely to miss details, draw incorrect conclusions, and make rash moves in an effort to regain control and obliterate the threat. That could be detrimental to your relationships and reputation. The next time you start to “lose it,” pause. Take some slow, deep breaths. This reduces the stress reactions. Notice what is upsetting you. Ask yourself why you feel threatened. Put it in context so it doesn't seem overwhelming. Tell yourself that it's time to be constructive. Talk your limbic system off the ledge so you can get back to using your PFC.

Tips to develop *Being* resilient

1. **Meeting resistance? Push through it.** Hesitate in the face of resistance? Do you backpedal? Give in too soon? Remember,

resistance is normal, not abnormal. Some of the time it's legitimate; most of the time it's just human nature. An unconscious defense mechanism. People resist until they understand. They are just protecting territory. Don't take it personally. Remind yourself what you are there to do. Return to the facts and your agenda. Keep making the business case. Invite the resisters in. Find out what's causing them to behave that way. Maybe your audience isn't ready to do what you need; it's not on their agenda. Help them understand what's in it for them. Invite their ideas, input, and critique. Listen. Adjust if you need to. Push ahead again.

2. **Lose confidence when challenged? Prepare to present a strong case.** Question your ability at the first sign of a challenge? Tell yourself that others are better, smarter than you? That this is never going to work? That your performance won't be good enough and that you are bound to fail? Confidence comes from having absolute belief in what you stand for. Being secure in yourself that you're on the right track. Being determined that this thing must get done. Feeling good about it. Do you feel good about yourself? Can you confidently defend to a critical and impartial audience the wisdom of what you're doing? Work on presenting your case. Practice mental interrogation until you can clearly state in a few sentences what you stand for. Use definite, direct language. People don't line up behind laundry lists or ambiguous objectives. Don't make what you're doing sound like a trial balloon. Don't be vague or tentative. Use the business case to support what you are asking for and to explain how everybody can gain. Do your homework. Anticipate tough questions, attacks, and countering views. Expect pushback. Rehearse how you will

respond. Practice your style, tone, pace, and volume. Plan as if you're only going to have one shot.

3. **Giving up after one or two tries? Try something different.** If you find yourself stuck in a repeating groove that's not working, it's time to switch approaches. To do something different. After all, if you always do what you've always done, you'll always get what you've always got. Don't give up. Identify what's getting in the way. If you think you might be missing something, take a step back. Look at the situation from a range of perspectives: yours, theirs, and that of an objective observer. Think about multiple ways to get the same outcome. Use the insights you gain to give yourself some advice about what to do differently. For example, to push a decision through, you could meet with stakeholders first, go to a single key stakeholder, study and present the problem to a group, call a problem-solving session, or call in an outside expert. Be prepared to do them all when obstacles arise. Persevere. Go back a second, third, or fourth time if you have to.
4. **Path blocked at every turn? Learn to navigate the maze.** Organizations can be complex mazes. Full of obstacles, with many turns and dead ends. Even worse, organizations are staffed with people, which makes it more complex. Egos. Gatekeepers. Resisters. The best path to get something done may not be direct. The formal organization works only some of the time. Most of the time, the informal organization runs the show. To overcome obstacles and drive things through, you have to know how to work the maze. Be prepared to tread new paths. Learn the informal organization. Identify the key players, especially the gatekeepers and the traffic controllers. Maybe the best way to

approach someone is through someone else. Maybe you have to work on your timing. Be patient with process. Things sometimes take time. People need to be ready to move. When is the best time to approach someone for a decision or an action? Ask others the best way to get things done in this organization. Watch others. What path do they follow?

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Hannon, K. (2012, December 26). 6 Key steps for career resilience. *Forbes*.

Ireland, K. (2013, August 16). *How to show self-confidence tips & tricks*. Livestrong.

Wakeman, C. (2009, June 8). A guide to dealing with resistant employees. *Fast Company*.

- 5. React defensively when criticized? Respond constructively instead.** There will always be people who are quick to criticize. To point out what you've done wrong. Tell you how something should be done differently. Sometimes it's well intended; sometimes it isn't. But, as Aristotle once said, the only way to avoid criticism is "...by saying nothing, doing nothing, and being nothing." Resist your natural impulse to react defensively. This is rarely a wise or productive move. It's emotionally driven and likely to make your critic feel attacked. It could escalate into conflict. Learn to respond instead by staying calm and pausing. Listen to and think about what you're hearing. Treat it as information, even if you don't agree with it or feel hurt. Accept you have flaws and that sometimes it's helpful to have these pointed out to you. Be open to the fact that others may be right. Pay attention to any

quality feedback that is being given. Focus on what you can learn. Apply constructive thinking. If the criticism feels unjust, ask your critic to repeat their viewpoint. Listen carefully. You may spot that it's based on a misunderstanding or different perspective. Work with them to straighten things out. When you choose your response, you are taking control of the situation and of your emotions. You'll make better choices about what you do with the information.

- 6. Trying to do too much? Regain your balance.** Being pulled in multiple directions? Managing conflicting demands? Lost your sense of priority? Trying to make everyone happy? Stop. You can't please all of the people all of the time. You can't fight every battle and hope to be effective. You only have a finite amount of energy and quality thinking time each day, so you need to balance it across the things that matter. Focus your effort on driving through the priorities. Not sure what they are? Establish them. Find out. Agree on them with your boss/stakeholders where you need to. Write them down. Use them to stay focused. Priorities act like a guiding compass when you're faced with managing conflicting demands. They help you maintain perspective in terms of what must be done. Be sure your priorities are right.
- 7. No energy? Get fit and healthy.** You need energy to be resilient. Physical and mental energy feed off of each other. Work on your physical fitness. Join a health club, walk, exercise, and eat well. Look after your mental well-being. Regularly engage in activities that you find mentally restorative. Develop a habit for a physical activity you enjoy and that makes you feel good. Practice yoga, mindfulness, or meditation techniques. Scientific studies show

doing things that “center” you can give your mind greater clarity. Renewed thinking. If you’re physically and mentally fit and healthy, you’ll have more energy. It’ll feel easier to attack and finish projects. Easier to stay focused and positive. To persevere when you feel like giving up. You’ll perform better, feel stronger.

8. **Blow up under pressure? Regulate your internal pressure gauge.** Demanding role? Challenging projects? Tough environment? Pressure building? Resilience being tested? Find ways to stay in control. Pressure can be productive if regulated effectively—just like a pressure cooker. Not enough pressure, the meal won’t cook. Too much and the lid will blow. Contents all over—a chaotic mess. Try to understand what causes you to blow up. Maybe your fuse is too long. You wait and wait. You keep concerns to yourself. Let the pressure build to the point where you’re unable to control its release, so you blow up. Maybe it’s too short and you don’t see the signs in time. Either way, uncontrolled pressure release is likely to have negative implications, for you and those around you. Regulate your internal pressure gauge. Learn how much pressure you need to be productive. Recognize the signals that the pressure’s getting too high. That you need to let off some steam. Maybe you’re faltering? Losing your confidence? Your composure? Agitating others? Find constructive ways to release the pent-up energy and emotion. Work on releasing your work frustration off-work. Get a physical hobby. Physical activity helps relieve pent-up energy. Detaches you from daily pressures. It also bumps up the production of endorphins, your brain’s feel-good neurotransmitters. These help combat the negative effects of stress. Try writing down what you’re concerned about. Talk about

it with confidantes and trusted coworkers. Take action as soon as you feel your pressure gauge rising. The sooner you can dissipate the unhelpful energy, the sooner you will bounce back to your baseline levels of composure and performance.

9. **Burning out? Learn to manage stress.** Physically and emotionally exhausted? Dread going to work? Trouble sleeping? Exhausted all the time? No interest in your work? Feeling overwhelmed? Getting short-tempered? These could be warning signs that your stress levels are too high and that you could be heading towards burnout. Stress can be caused by anything. Your daily commute. Heavy workload. Difficult customers. Delivering results quarter after quarter. It’s different for everyone. Unchecked, it can affect your productivity and, worse still, your health. Find out what situations cause you to become stressed. Keep a stress diary. Make an entry after any stressful event. Note down when it happened. How you felt about it. How high your stress level became on a scale of 0–10. How you responded. How your response helped or hindered the situation. Any physical or emotional reaction (sweaty palms, tears, etc.). Review your diary entries regularly and establish what situations cause you the most stress. How do they affect your productivity? Your health? What can you do to change these situations for the better? What strategies will help you deal with them? Some stress at work will be unavoidable and resilience means recognizing and responding to your signals early. Finding better ways to manage stress and pressure. Talk to your boss or mentor about getting some relief if you’re about to crumble. If you feel you’re already burned out, maybe think about moving to a less stressful job.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Collingwood, J. (2010). *Dealing with anger constructively*. Psych Central.

Goudreau, J. (2013, March 20). 12 Ways to eliminate stress at work. *Forbes*.

Mayo Clinic Staff. (2013). *Coping with stress: Workplace tips*. Mayo Clinic.

10. Lost your passion? Rediscover what matters. Heart's not in it anymore? Hard to stay positive? Not 100% committed? Maybe you don't bounce back or drive to overcome difficulties because deep down you don't care anymore—you're sick of doing this job or working for this organization or pushing against a particular person or group. Ask what it is that you want. Find your passion again. To make the best of your current job, make a list of what you like and don't like to do. Concentrate on doing more liked activities each day. Work to delegate or task trade the things that are no longer motivating to you. Do your least preferred activities first to get them out of the way; focus not on the activity, but on your sense of accomplishment. Change your work activity to mirror your interests as much as you can. Volunteer for task forces and projects that would be motivating for you.

11. Caught off guard by crises? Prepare for them. Resilience is a key skill for crisis management. When a crisis strikes, you need to keep a firm, confident hand on the tiller. During a crisis, time is the enemy. Pressure is high and quick action is needed. So be prepared for them. Learn to anticipate them. Come up with signal detectors—such as an increase in costs or threats—for all

potential crises. Collect all the data you can. Think through all of the worst-case consequences and assign a person or a team to prepare for them. When a crisis strikes, use the data you have and ask others for suggestions and thoughts. Decide and execute decisions with an instant feedback loop. Make adjustments to your course as you go. Stay focused and in control. And communicate, communicate, communicate.

12. Suffered a setback? Take positive action. Setbacks can happen at any time and are caused by many things. Environmental factors. Or individual mistakes. Whatever the cause, it can be easy to be thrown off track and harder to bounce back. Maybe you're embarrassed? Perhaps you feel you've failed, lost the battle. Recognize what has happened and accept your own role in the situation. Bring yourself to a physical and emotional state where you can focus on moving forward. Confront the issue. Plan your recovery. Ask yourself: What do I want to have happen? What is within my control? What do I have influence over? How can I make the most immediate, positive difference in this situation? What's the best and worst outcome from here? What do I want success to look like on the other side of this setback? How can I get there quickly? What will I do first? Don't retreat into isolation. Surround yourself with wise counsel—people who will help you stay balanced. Challenge your perspective. Guide you through making the tough decisions. Encourage you to keep going; to recover quickly. Resilience is about taking action. A positive step forward, a small win, a new goal that takes attention off of the past and creates excitement about the future. A belief that you will succeed eventually.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Kleiman, J. (2013, January 28). 7 Ways to bounce back from career mistakes, missteps, and misunderstandings. *Forbes*.

Levin, H. (2012, May 3). *How to stay motivated at work*. Fox Business.

Ryan, J. R. (2010, June 11). Four ideas for a positive workforce. *Bloomberg Businessweek*.

Job assignments

- Take on a task or assignment that you dislike doing. Manage your own resistance to driving it through.
- Prepare and present, with confidence, a significant proposal to your management team. Anticipate the resistance you may get and prepare to counter it.
- Offer to take the lead on getting a derailed project back on track. Dig beneath the surface to find out what went wrong so you can work out how things need to be approached differently.
- Solicit constructive criticism from a customer or stakeholder that you've had trouble with or find it hard to get along with. Look for what you can learn from the information you receive.
- Develop and implement your own personal stress- and pressure-management plan. Seek input from experts who can help guide you.

Take time to reflect...

If you feel like giving up when people push back...

...then ask yourself if you tend to give up too soon. Don't be discouraged by resistance. If your goal is worthwhile, you owe it to yourself to persist.

If you find it hard to stay focused when the pressure is on...

...then find your release valve to reduce your stress levels. Keep things in perspective. Talk to trusted friends. Find ways to laugh.

If you're feeling drained from things not working out...

...then take a break from the battle. Do whatever re-energizes you most. Recharge your batteries. Return to the situation with renewed vigor and focus.

"It's hard to beat a person who never gives up."

Babe Ruth – American baseball player and member of the Baseball Hall of Fame



Learn more about **Being resilient**

Beer, M. (2009). *High commitment high performance: How to build a resilient organization for sustained advantage*. San Francisco, CA: Jossey-Bass.

Cashman, K. (2008). *Leadership from the inside out: Becoming a leader for life*. San Francisco, CA: Berrett-Kohler Publishers.

Paulson, T. L. (2010). *The optimism advantage: 50 simple truths to transform your attitudes and actions into results*. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley & Sons.

Trestman, M. (2010). *Perseverance: Life lessons on leadership and teamwork*. Edina, MN: Bernstein Books.

Zolli, A., & Healy, A. M. (2013). *Resilience: Why things bounce back*. New York, NY: Simon & Schuster.



Deep dive learning resource links

Collingwood, J. (2010). *Dealing with anger constructively*. Psych Central. Retrieved from <http://psychcentral.com/lib/dealing-with-anger-constructively/0003155>

Goudreau, J. (2013, March 20). 12 Ways to eliminate stress at work. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/jennagoudreau/2013/03/20/12-ways-to-eliminate-stress-at-work/>

Hannon, K. (2012, December 26). 6 Key steps for career resilience. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/kerryhannon/2012/12/26/6-key-steps-for-career-resilience/>

Ireland, K. (2013, August 16). *How to show self-confidence tips & tricks*. Livestrong. Retrieved from <http://www.livestrong.com/article/191199-how-to-show-self-confidence-tips-tricks/>

Kleiman, J. (2013, January 28). 7 Ways to bounce back from career mistakes, missteps, and misunderstandings. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/work-in-progress/2013/01/28/7-ways-to-bounce-back-from-career-mistakes-missteps-and-misunderstandings/>

Levin, H. (2012, May 3). *How to stay motivated at work*. Fox Business. Retrieved from <http://www.foxbusiness.com/personal-finance/2012/05/03/how-to-stay-motivated-at-work/>

Mayo Clinic Staff. (2013). *Coping with stress: Workplace tips*. Mayo Clinic. Retrieved from <http://www.mayoclinic.org/coping-with-stress/art-20048369>

Ryan, J. R. (2010, June 11). Four ideas for a positive workforce. *Bloomberg Businessweek*. Retrieved from http://www.businessweek.com/managing/content/jun2010/ca2010068_804146.htm

Wakeman, C. (2009, June 8). A guide to dealing with resistant employees. *Fast Company*. Retrieved from <http://www.fastcompany.com/1293211/guide-dealing-resistant-employees>

Recommended search terms

If you'd like to explore *Being* resilient further, try searching online using the following terms:

- Becoming resilient.
- Being persistent at work.
- Building perseverance.
- Showing confidence at work.
- Working through resistance.



More help...

Go to www.kornferry.com/fyi-resources and link directly to the deep dive resources in this chapter. Visit the site often to see the additional resources that are uploaded on a regular basis.



27. RESOURCEFULNESS

Securing and deploying resources effectively and efficiently.

So much to do; so little time to do it. Finite resources; infinite needs. Everyone having more to do than they can get to. Sound familiar? That's life in organizations today. There are often more opportunities than there are people, time, and money available. Most anyone can produce results, given unlimited resources. The real trick is to produce results by making the best use of the limited resources available. Resourcefulness means finding a way to get things done, even when the odds are against you. Not getting stalled at the first roadblock but, instead, looking beyond the obvious for other viable approaches to accomplishing the goal. Knowing how to find and secure scant resources. Orchestrating efforts so that assignments are executed efficiently and effectively. Challenging yourself to do more with less. And redefining what's possible.



*"It's not the lack of resources,
it's your lack of resourcefulness that stops you."*

Tony Robbins – American entrepreneur and motivational speaker

Resourcefulness is in the **Results** factor (II) in the Korn Ferry Leadership Architect™. It is part of Cluster D, **Taking initiative**, along with Action oriented (2). You may find it helpful to also take a look at some of the tips included in that chapter to supplement your learning.

Skilled

- ★ **Marshals resources (people, funding, material, support) to get things done.**
- ★ **Orchestrates multiple activities simultaneously to accomplish a goal.**
- ★ **Gets the most out of limited resources.**
- ★ **Applies knowledge of internal structures, processes, and culture to resourcing efforts.**

Less skilled

- Has difficulty figuring out where to get resources.
- Relies on the same resources over and over.
- Gets frustrated and becomes inefficient when things don't go as planned.
- Tries to impose one way of doing things; doesn't adjust swiftly enough.

Talented

- Gets the most out of available resources and secures rare resources others can't get.
- Adapts quickly to changing resource requirements.
- Enjoys multi-tasking; applies knowledge of the organization to advance multiple objectives.

Overused skill

- Stretches available resources beyond capacity.
- Hoards resources from others.
- Sometimes gathers resources too far ahead of time or obtains excess resources.
- Diverts too quickly from planned approach when something unexpected happens.

Some possible causes of lower skill

Causes help explain *why* a person may have trouble with Resourcefulness. When seeking to increase skill, it's helpful to consider how these might play out in certain situations. And remember that all of these can be addressed if you are motivated to do so.

- Poor planner.
- Disorganized.
- Doesn't delegate.
- Not flexible.
- Inexperienced.
- Slow decision maker.
- Poor time management.

- Uncomfortable with ambiguity.



Did you know?

Resourcefulness is such an integral part of life in bustling India, it has given rise to a particularly Indian form of innovation known as *jugaad*. Tracing its popular roots to Indian farmers' construction of jitney-like vehicles from scrap wood and irrigation pump motors, *jugaad* has found its way into the management lexicon as companies increasingly turn to "frugal innovation" practices to fuel their R&D operations. Recent innovations in everything from cars to medical devices to mobile banking all owe some inspiration to the principles of *jugaad*.

Tips to develop Resourcefulness

1. **Need a plan? Lay out the work.** Resourcefulness starts out with a plan. A good plan helps everyone who has to work under it. It leads to better use of resources and facilitates getting things done efficiently. Lay out the work from A to Z. What are your goals? What's mission critical and what's trivial? What's the time line? What resources will you need? Who controls the resources (time, people, funding, tools, materials, support)? What's your currency? How can you pay for or repay the resources you need? Break complex and multi-tracked projects down into a series of tasks. Ask others to comment on your ordering and note what's missing. When you're ready, set the plan. Use flowcharting or project planning software that does PERT and Gantt charts. Set aside 20 minutes at the start of each week to review your plan, prioritize, and manage your resources.

2. **Wasting time? Invest it wisely.** Your time and that of others is a precious resource not to be wasted. At some point, everyone has wished for more hours in the day. Be time sensitive. Accurately plan your time and the time you need from others and manage against it. Set deadlines for yourself. Use your best time of day for the toughest and most critical projects—your “A” tasks. If you’re best in the morning, don’t waste it on “B” and “C” level tasks. Don’t secure and deploy resources too early or too late in a project; both can lead to time being wasted. Attach a monetary value to time. Figure out what you and your other people resources are worth per hour based on gross salary plus overhead and benefits. Then ask: Is this task worth that amount of time and money? What would be a more valuable investment? Remember that the higher up you go, the higher the monetary value on time will be.
3. **Difficulty securing all you need? Work with what you have.** You can’t always delay taking action while you wait to get every last bit of resources that you need. It might never happen and doing nothing is likely not an option. Have the courage to make a start. Be clear about what resources you have, where they are, and what they can do. Focus on what can be achieved. Visualize how you can achieve what you need to. If you were making the most of the resources you have, what would you be doing? What’s the best possible result you could deliver? Invite others who are involved to offer suggestions on how to best use the available resources. Be pragmatic. Manage stakeholder expectations where you need to and start small where you have to. But start anyway.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

- Kimbrell, G. (2014, January 31). Four project management lessons you can learn from software engineers. *Forbes*.
- Larson, E., & Larson, R. (2004, September 10). How to create a clear project plan. *CIO Magazine*.
- Saunders, E. G. (2013, January 7). How to allocate your time, and your effort. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*.
- Trammell, J. (2013, June 18). The resource allocation dilemma faced by CEOs every single day. *Forbes*.
-

4. **Operating on a shoestring? Bargain for resources.** Sometimes you’ll need to be creative to get what you need. That means learning to bargain, negotiate, trade, cajole, and influence. What can you borrow? What do you have that you can trade? What do you need to trade for? Who do you know that could help? What could you provide in return? How can you make it a win for everyone? Use relationships to help where you can; find people in your network to borrow from. Working internationally? Adjust your resource-bargaining approach to match the local culture. Worried you may be pushing the ethics envelope? Study up on the legal practices of the country in which you are operating and how they may influence or limit what you can do. If you are operating in a questionable area, get help from legal or others who have worked in similar situations.
5. **Money tight? Watch the budget.** Be clear on exactly what funding you have and plan spending carefully. Write down all your funding sources along with when each element of funding will be available. Make a list of the costs you’re anticipating and when

they are likely to occur. Which are fixed and which might vary? Align the funding coming in to the expenditures going out. If you can, have a reserve in case the unexpected comes up. Projected spending higher than the funding available? Look at the variable costs to find areas to cut back. Or work backwards—take the funding you have available and consider how to best spend it in line with what needs to be delivered. Set up a funding time line to track ongoing expenditures. Review your spending regularly to keep on track.

6. **Not getting the most out of people resources? Delegate.** On long, complex, multi-track projects, you can't do everything yourself. Your people resources each come with a unique set of skills, knowledge, experience, and ideas. All available for you to tap into. Get comfortable giving up control. Give away as much as possible along with the authority that goes with it. Be clear on the outcome required but open on how it's achieved. Give people leeway, encourage experimentation. One clear finding in research is that people are more motivated when they have control over their work, can determine how to do it, and have the authority to make decisions. It's also developmental. Telling them how to do it may help you in the short-term, but if people just carry out your instructions, they won't grow. Agree on boundaries and authority levels. Give context to the bigger strategic picture—take three extra minutes to talk about its importance to the goals and objectives of the unit.
7. **Limited pool of resources to draw upon? Observe master resource builders in action.** Do you tend to rely on the same resources over and over? Amazed by others who get resources

from far and wide? Who find and secure the rare resources others can't? Don't just wonder at them, actively observe their behavior. How do they get things done? How do they use internal culture, structures, and processes to get what they need? How do they influence and negotiate? What tactics do they use to expedite things through the organizational maze? How do they use their networks? Who do they rely on for help and to get things done? What relationship do they have with the gatekeepers who control the flow of resources? Compare your approach to theirs. What do they do that you don't? Who do they know that you don't? Get to know them better; use them as a mentor. Learn their strategies then borrow them for yourself.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Green, H. (2012, June 12). Four strategies for getting it done in your organization. *Forbes*.

Lawrence, L., Hernandez Requejo, W., & Graham, J. L. (2011, June 28). Negotiating over a limited resource: What would you do? *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*.

Mind Tools. (n.d.). *Successful delegation: Using the power of other people's help*. Mind Tools.

Westland, J. (2011, June 23). Project management: 4 Ways to manage your budget. *CIO Magazine*.

8. **Overwhelmed? Manage your state of mind.** Think it can't be done? That it'll never work? This is negative self-talk. It reinforces beliefs that limit what is possible. Learn to eliminate negative self-talk and replace it with something more helpful. Look at complex problems and hold the belief that they can be solved, even when

others are telling you otherwise. Turn negatives like “I can’t do this” or “This is impossible” into positive questions: “How can I do this?” “How is this possible?” It shifts your thinking from the problem to the solution. From what you can’t do to what you can do. What you think shapes your reality. And in the words of Henry Ford, “Whether you think you can, or you think you can’t—you’re right.”

- 9. Frustrated when things don’t go according to plan? Expect the unexpected.** Are you a perfectionist? Create plans and expect to follow them without deviation? Get frustrated when circumstances change? Even the best laid plans go astray when the unexpected happens. Resourcefulness is about knowing this and preparing for it. Build contingency into your resources where you can. Have a Plan B as well as a Plan A. Anticipate changes in circumstances and prepare how you might respond. What will you do if you lose some of your resources? If the time lines are tightened? Funding cut? Stay calm when the unexpected does happen. Take an objective look at what’s changed and avoid the urge to act impulsively. Don’t waste time and energy on things you can’t change. Focus on what you *can* do. Ask questions that provoke resourceful thinking. What result am I working toward? Where am I now? What’s my best option? What do I have influence and/or control over? How much do I need to adapt my plan? What help do I need? What adjustments do I need to make to my resources—time, people, funding, etc.? Adapt swiftly. Remember, resourcefulness is measured by the ability to achieve the outcome, not follow the plan.

- 10. Stuck with one way of doing things? Be creative.** Resourcefulness is, in part, about finding creative new ways of doing things. Experimenting when an initial approach doesn’t work. If you find yourself relying on the same methods time after time, reflect on what’s preventing you from being more creative. Fear of failure? Creative people see failure as an opportunity to learn. Worried what people may think? Being creative means putting up the new and unique for review and critique. Get out of your comfort zone. Beware of “I have always...” or “Usually, I...” Focus on “What haven’t I tried” or “What would happen if...” Learn from others who’ve achieved the outcome you’re seeking. Find out what made them effective. Take a risk. Don’t carelessly disregard the rules, but do find unconventional ways to do things if it helps. Be prepared to explain yourself and apologize if you overstep. Think and act differently; try new things; break free of your restraints.
- 11. Think there’s only one way to get things done? Try different solutions and learn from the results.** Don’t expect to get it right the first time. A low-risk, perfectionist mindset leads to safe and stale solutions. Many studies show that the second or third try is when we really understand the underlying dynamics of problems. To increase learning, shorten your action time and get feedback loops—aiming to make them as immediate as possible. The more frequent the cycles, the more opportunities to learn. If we do something in each of three days instead of one thing every three days, we triple our learning opportunities and increase our chances of finding the right answer.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Clark, N. F. (2013, July 15). A surprising way to get things done on time. *Forbes*.

Conlon, C. (2011, October 12). *7 Wise ways to find focus and get things done*. Life Hack.

Mayo Clinic Staff. (2011, May 28). *Positive thinking: Reduce stress by eliminating negative self-talk*. Mayo Clinic.

Pitagorsky, G. (2011, January 26). Project managers are change managers. *Project Times*.

Job assignments

- Offer to lead an underresourced project that requires you to bargain and trade with others to get what you need to succeed.
- Begin something from scratch that requires your bringing a team together and initiating simultaneous actions under a tight time frame.
- Take on a task where you've failed in the past. Push yourself outside your comfort zone and experiment with new ways of achieving success.
- Consider tasks that are no longer developmental for you but would be for others, and delegate them.
- Volunteer to plan an off-site meeting, conference, convention, trade show, or other event where you're almost certain to encounter changing requirements and obstacles that will test your resourcefulness.

Take time to reflect...

If the task seems impossible with the resources you have...

...then renegotiate and refocus. Figure out what's possible with limited resources. The resources that have brought you this far can probably take you even further. Use old tools in new ways. Improvise and adapt. Find a way.

If your "go to" resources have got up and gone...

...then recognize the risks of relying on the same sources again and again. Seek out new options. Use your knowledge of your environment. Tap into connections. Always be on the lookout.

If you don't have what you need to get the job done...

...then consider that the solution doesn't always stare you in the face. Look beyond the obvious. Get creative. Think possibilities and "what ifs." Sometimes the most unlikely options turn out to be the best fit.

"I will either find a way or make one."

Hannibal – Punic Carthaginian military commander



Learn more about Resourcefulness

Achor, S. (2010). *The happiness advantage: The seven principles of positive psychology that fuel success and performance at work*. New York, NY: Crown Business.

- Chandler, S. (2011). *Time warrior: How to defeat procrastination, people-pleasing, self-doubt, over-commitment, broken promises and chaos*. Anna Maria, FL: Maurice Bassett.
- Gordon, J. (2008). *The no complaining rule: Positive ways to deal with negativity at work*. Hoboken, NJ: John Wiley & Sons, Inc.
- Hall, D. (2013). *Time management: How to take charge of your schedule, reduce stress, be productive, and effective!* [Kindle edition]. Amazon Digital Services.
- Kerzner, H. R. (2009). *Project management: A systems approach to planning, scheduling, and controlling*. Hoboken, NJ: John Wiley & Sons, Inc.



Deep dive learning resource links

- Clark, N. F. (2013, July 15). A surprising way to get things done on time. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/womensmedia/2013/07/15/a-surprising-way-to-get-things-done-on-time/>
- Conlon, C. (2011, October 12). *7 Wise ways to find focus and get things done*. Life Hack. Retrieved from <http://www.lifehack.org/articles/productivity/7-wise-ways-to-find-focus-and-get-things-done.html>
- Green, H. (2012, June 12). Four strategies for getting it done in your organization. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/work-in-progress/2012/06/12/four-strategies-for-getting-it-done-in-your-organization/>

- Kimbrell, G. (2014, January 31). Four project management lessons you can learn from software engineers. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/theyec/2014/01/31/four-project-management-lessons-you-can-learn-from-software-engineers/>
- Larson, E., & Larson, R. (2004, September 10). How to create a clear project plan. *CIO Magazine*. Retrieved from http://www.cio.com.au/article/166486/how_create_clear_project_plan/
- Lawrence, L., Hernandez Requejo, W., & Graham, J. L. (2011, June 28). Negotiating over a limited resource: What would you do? *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*. Retrieved from <http://blogs.hbr.org/2011/06/negotiating-over-a-limited-res/>
- Mayo Clinic Staff. (2011, May 28). *Positive thinking: Reduce stress by eliminating negative self-talk*. Mayo Clinic. Retrieved from <http://www.mayoclinic.org/positive-thinking/art-20043950>
- Mind Tools. (n.d.). *Successful delegation: Using the power of other people's help*. Mind Tools. Retrieved from http://www.mindtools.com/pages/article/newLDR_98.htm
- Pitagorsky, G. (2011, January 26). Project managers are change managers. *Project Times*. Retrieved from <http://www.projecttimes.com/george-pitagorsky/project-managers-are-change-managers.html>
- Saunders, E. G. (2013, January 7). How to allocate your time, and your effort. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*. Retrieved from <http://blogs.hbr.org/2013/01/how-to-allocate-your-time-and/>
- Trammell, J. (2013, June 18). The resource allocation dilemma faced by CEOs every single day. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/joeltrammell/2013/06/18/the-resource-allocation-dilemma-faced-by-ceos-every-single-day/>

Westland, J. (2011, June 23). Project management: 4 Ways to manage your budget. *CIO Magazine*. Retrieved from http://www.cio.com/article/684978/Project_Management_4_Ways_to_Manage_Your_Budget

Recommended search terms

If you'd like to explore Resourcefulness further, try searching online using the following terms:

- Bargaining for limited resources.
- How to work with limited resources.
- Planning your time effectively.
- Reducing negative self-talk.
- Using different strategies to get things done.



More help...

Go to www.kornferry.com/fyi-resources and link directly to the deep dive resources in this chapter. Visit the site often to see the additional resources that are uploaded on a regular basis.



28. DRIVES RESULTS

Consistently achieving results, even under tough circumstances.

Driving results is an overall achievement mindset, a bias for action, an eagerness to take the initiative. People who drive for results infuse their teams and organizations with a sense of urgency. They help create a culture where organizational performance is always top of mind. Results might be quantifiable—measured in terms of P&L, sales growth, customer satisfaction ratings, new products launched. Or results may be qualitative—an enhanced reputation among customers, a more vibrant brand that attracts customers and employee talent. In successful organizations, the efforts of individuals, teams, functions, departments, and business units are aligned around these objectives. Driving results means communicating a vision, setting priorities, developing and executing plans that achieve the desired outcome—for the organization and the world. As a leader, you *must* be willing to act and follow through to drive results.



*"If my mind can conceive it,
and my heart can believe it,
I know I can achieve it!"*

Jesse Jackson – American civil rights activist

Drives results is in the **Results** factor (II) in the Korn Ferry Leadership Architect™. It is part of Cluster F, **Focusing on performance**, along with *Ensures* accountability (1). You may find it helpful to also take a look at some of the tips included in that chapter to supplement your learning.

Skilled

- ★ **Has a strong bottom-line orientation.**
- ★ **Persists in accomplishing objectives despite obstacles and setbacks.**
- ★ **Has a track record of exceeding goals successfully.**
- ★ **Pushes self and helps others achieve results.**

Less skilled

- Is reluctant to push for results.
- Does the least to get by.
- Is an inconsistent performer.
- Gives up easily; doesn't go back with different strategies for the third and fourth try.
- Often misses deadlines.
- Procrastinates around whatever gets in the way.

Talented

- Sets aggressive goals and has high standards.
- Is consistently one of the top performers.
- Pursues everything with energy, drive, and the need to finish.
- Persists in the face of challenges and setbacks.
- Always keeps the end in sight; puts in extra effort to meet deadlines.

Overused skill

- Goes for results at all costs without appropriate concern for people, teams, due process, or possibly norms and ethics.
- May be so deadline oriented that he/she pushes to get something done rather than taking the time to do it right.
- Even in the face of near insurmountable obstacles, sticks with the effort beyond reason.
- Puts too much pressure on self and others to achieve the impossible.
- May not celebrate and share successes.

Some possible causes of lower skill

Causes help explain *why* a person may have trouble with *Drives* results. When seeking to increase skill, it's helpful to consider how these might play out in certain situations. And remember that all of these can be addressed if you are motivated to do so.

- Loses focus.
- Disorganized.
- Not strategic.

- Procrastinates.
- Sets unrealistic expectations.
- Poor planner.
- Burned out.
- Afraid of mistakes.
- Lacks commitment and accountability.



Brain booster

So driven that you can't relax? For the highest achievers, it can be hard to stop and take a break, but it turns out that rest and relaxation is exactly what helps us maintain high levels of achievement. This may feel like a paradox, but conduct your own experiment to see for yourself. Research has shown that short naps improve the vigilance and judgment of air traffic controllers. Getting a full night's sleep improves memory. Staying unplugged on vacation decreases the likelihood that you'll leave your company. Stepping away, switching off, relaxing, and protecting your workout time all contribute to higher productivity and better job performance. While wishing for more hours in your day is futile, wishing for more energy during your day is achievable.

Tips to develop *Drives* results

1. **Have a big idea? Convert it to action.** Ever get on board with a big initiative, only to run out of steam? Create inspiring plans in an off-site and then forget about them? Or set an audacious goal in January and lose track of it by February? Big ideas produce big results over the long haul. In fact, they can be downright

transformative. But to see results, you need to translate ideas into action. If you are part of something big, keep it front of mind by making it visible. Post a photo or other reminder on your screensaver so you see it every time you open your laptop. Create a visual model or time line and share it with others. If it involves the whole organization, get HR, marketing, communications, or other relevant groups involved. Create a communications plan. Put time on the calendar to get things moving. A vision is just a good idea until you take action.

2. **Not bold enough? Take reasonable risks.** Won't take a risk? Micromanaging to avoid mistakes? Running another analysis of last month's figures? Rethinking decisions? If this is you, practice pushing yourself forward. Sometimes producing results involves taking chances and trying bold new initiatives. Doing those things leads to more misfires and mistakes but sometimes better results. Treat any mistakes or failures as chances to learn. Nothing ventured, nothing gained. Up your risk comfort. To get results, you need to keep things moving. Making decisions. Approving plans. Start small so you can recover more quickly. See how creative and innovative you can be. Let go of perfection and aim for excellence. Satisfy yourself; people will always say it should have been done differently. Listen to them, but be skeptical. Ask yourself what's at stake. And what's the worst that can happen. Then turn the question around: What good things will *not* happen if you fail to act? Allow reasonable time to consider options, then make the best decision possible. Conduct a postmortem immediately after finishing. This will indicate to all that you're open to continuous improvement whether the result was stellar or not.

3. **Procrastinator? Start now.** Are you a lifelong procrastinator? Do you perform best in crises and under impossible deadlines? Do you wait until the last possible moment? If you do, you may miss deadlines and performance targets. You might not produce consistent results. Some of your work will be marginal because you didn't have the time to do it right. You settled for a B when you could have gotten an A if you had one more day to work on it. And you might be causing yourself and your teammates unnecessary stress. Save "crisis mode" for your own time. When others are depending on you, get going. Start earlier. Try doing 10% of each task immediately after it is assigned so you can better gauge what it is going to take to finish the rest. Divide tasks and assignments into thirds and schedule time to do them spaced over the delivery period. Let others know how you are progressing. Always leave more time than you think it's going to take.
4. **Overwhelmed? Focus on priorities.** You're already working at top speed on a full schedule. Then your boss asks you to take on something new—right now. You feel like you need to go in eight different directions and don't know where to start. Before you panic, do some planning. What's mission-critical? What are the three to five things that most need to get done to achieve your goals? Effective performers typically spend about half their time on a few mission-critical priorities. Don't get diverted by trivia and things you like doing but aren't tied to the bottom line. When you've laid out your top priorities, identify a few critical action steps that will move you forward on each one. Notice what is demanding immediate attention—and what is actually already on track. Put some space on your calendar to take care of what is

important but not urgent now. Then take care of the urgent. This planning will take just a few minutes and will get you back on track. If you're still uptight, ask for help. And remember to manage your expectations of yourself: as good as you may be, you can't be in two places at once.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Driscoll, M. (2013, July 18). Research: Why companies keep getting blind-sided by risk. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*.

Giang, V. (2012, March 18). *15 Ways to stop procrastinating right now*. Business Insider.

Llopis, G. (2013, April 1). The 12 things that successfully convert a great idea into a reality. *Forbes*.

Mind Tools. (n.d.). *Taking initiative: Making things happen in the workplace*. Mind Tools.

- 5. Problem getting work done through others? Focus on the fundamentals.** Many people can produce results themselves but struggle to make the transition to getting results from the team. Having trouble getting your team to work with you to get the results you need? Have the resources and the people but things just don't run well? Maybe you do too much of the work yourself. You don't delegate or empower. You don't communicate well. Struggle to motivate. Plan poorly. Find prioritizing difficult. You may need to learn the basics of delegation and good management. To let go of doing it all yourself. To learn to show others what you want done—and let them do it. To paint a clear picture of what is important and why. Delegation is a complex

skill. It takes effort to show others what you want. But it pays off over time. The team will become stronger. Results will be better. Read *Becoming a Manager* by Linda A. Hill. Learn from others around you who delegate well.

- 6. Trouble getting buy-in? Listen before you act.** Focused on action? Eager to get started? Anxious to get results? These are great qualities for getting to the bottom line. But if you're driving results through others, you need to slow down and include them in your thinking. People can't follow you if they don't know where you are going, and why. Give them the big picture of what needs to happen. Invite them to flesh out ideas and plans. Work with them to define plans and expectations. Help them prioritize their own efforts. Start with a brainstorming session. "Here's what we need to do. How can we do this?" Collaborate on creating a plan. Or hand it off to them. Check in. Stay involved to see how things are going. Let them know how their efforts align with the organizational goals.

- 7. People not committed? Set stretch goals and stay involved.** High expectations are great. But if goals are perceived as unachievable, people become skeptical and discouraged. They give up and performance lags. Or, if goals are too low, boredom sets in and performance lags. People lose interest and end up underperforming. Setting stretching but achievable goals shows confidence. It creates optimism and an expectation for success. But don't just set goals. Ask what is needed to get there. Get the resources and support you need—and set checkpoints along the way to measure progress. Give yourself and others as much feedback as you can. Get buy-in. Recognize improvement.

Celebrate success. Then agree on next steps to even higher performance.

8. Group not performing? Address team dynamics. Leading a stalled project? In danger of missing the goal? Delivering subpar performance? Every group and team is made up of individuals. Some who may be giving more than others. Some who may be willing but struggling. Some may have “checked out” for reasons of their own. If this is happening, assess the team as a whole. Does it have an agreed-upon goal? The right mix of skills? The resources it needs? Adequate support from the organization? Make the changes you need to make to ensure results are achieved. Look at individuals. Do you need to switch out some team members or bring in new skills? Encourage different working relationships? Stimulate new collaborations? Address conflict? Figure out what’s not working and make it right. Ask HR for help or bring in a team consultant if you are really stumped.

9. Getting resistance? Deal with objections. It’s your job to drive a major change initiative. You’ve got your resources, your time line, your plans. Everything looks good. Until a key group or person raises objections. Why are we doing this? What will this cost? Why are we changing what we’ve done for 20 years? The best change leaders don’t get derailed by pushback. They anticipate resistance. They are equipped to handle the heat of controversy. They allow time to hear objections. Individual meetings. Town halls. Phone conferences. They answer objections and make course corrections. But they don’t lose sight of the endgame. The vision. The results. Encourage more objections. If you sense people are holding back, get concerns out on the table. Ask for

specifics. Dig deep. Get to the root of the resistance. Understand what’s behind the dissent. See it from their point of view. If you were in their shoes, what would you need to hear to be converted?

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Gleeson, B. (2012, December 28). Setting stretch goals: All in, all the time. *Inc.*

Hill, L., & Lineback, K. (2012, April 3). Good managers lead through a team. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network.*

Russell, N. S. (2013, February 8). Six ways to get things done when you’re not the boss. *Forbes.*

Sevier, R. A. (2006, September). Moving a team forward. *University Business.*

10. Derailed by the unexpected? Define and address the problem.

You’re working hard, focused on getting things done. Then something unexpected happens. A system glitch destroys last night’s work. An important meeting gets cancelled. Maybe you get stuck in traffic and arrive at the office two hours late. When you are thrown off track by the unexpected, you have two choices. You can either tense up, throw up your hands, snap at a few coworkers, and generally make the situation worse, or you can take a breath, stay calm, and find a way around or through the situation. Pick up the phone, get on e-mail, reach out to others, and work the problem. Use your brain, use your resources. Envision a good outcome. Shift your attitude from “Why is this happening to me?” to “Interesting development. Let’s see what we can do with it.”

- 11. Disorganized? Use systems to stay on track.** Running late? Missed a phone call? Lost a critical e-mail? When you're going in more than one direction, the occasional slip-up is inevitable. But you can't consistently deliver results if you can't stay on top of the details. Use systems to have a fighting chance of completing things on time and within budget. Log contact info into your phone or e-mail system. Deal with e-mail two to three times a day. Answer, forward, or act on anything you can. File the rest in project folders and put time on your calendar for follow-up. Have a to-do list or system for immediate tasks. Look at it at the beginning or end of the day. Add new items; delete those you've completed. Learn some basic Excel skills to create simple project sheets. Use just one calendar. Color code your files and tasks. Use mobile technology to access your e-mail and calendar on the go. Learn to live without paper. Back up your laptop. Remember that when it comes to being organized, less is more.
- 12. Tempted to quit before the end? Refocus and stick with it.** It may be tempting to reduce your efforts when the end is in sight. After all, your customers have been delighted with the new products. The economy has run strong all year. Things are going well, so results are in the bag—right? Not necessarily. Surprises happen. Contracts get cancelled. Opportunities and sure things fizzle out. Markets crash. If you find your attention flagging, refocus. Winning teams play with the same intensity the whole game, no matter the score. Driving for results means not quitting before the end. Getting results means sticking with the project until it is completed successfully. Keep up a review of what has been done, what remains to be done, and where results will come from. Be persistent. Follow through on every task. Sometimes

you'll head off a disaster. Sometimes you'll find an unexpected late win. Check the details. It's not over until it's over.

- 13. Lost in the detail? Focus on the essentials.** Good with the detail? Pride yourself on your expertise? Remember names, dates, and places? Can relate the history of any product your company ever produced? Have the answer to any question? Being this detail oriented doesn't mean you're the quickest to get results. While you're stuck in what you know, the people around you want to move on. To create the next generation of products. To adopt some new ideas. To get up to speed, you don't need to abandon valuable detail. But you do need to streamline your thinking—and your communication. Focus on the endpoint and ask yourself, "How much detail is needed to paint the picture and move us forward?" Use what is needed now. Archive or jettison the rest.
- 14. Driving too hard? Learn to manage stress.** Pride yourself on exceeding goals? Push yourself every day to produce? Always ready for a challenge? Individual responses to stress vary. But for most people, driving for results day after day, quarter after quarter, year after year is stressful. If you're close to burnout or if people can't keep up with you, you're overdoing it. Sustainable performance requires rest and recovery. Athletes train hard, then enjoy the off-season. Performance will improve if you disconnect once in a while. Use your commute to work to get perspective. Enjoy friends and family. Make personal connections at work. Stop to celebrate wins. Learn to take pride in your great results, but balance action with recovery. Take a time out.

Want to learn more? Take a deep dive...

Grant Halvorson, H. (2011, June 22). How to become a great finisher. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*.

Mayo Clinic Staff. (2011, May 28). *Positive thinking: Reduce stress by eliminating negative self-talk*. Mayo Clinic.

Stolovitsky, N. (2010, August 4). *Planning for the unplanned: Including risk in your project management strategy*. Genius Project.

Wilkinson, M. (2010, June 18). *Why perseverance is an essential quality to possess in the workplace*. Career Path 360.

Job assignments

- Lead a team in launching a new product or service with a large potential impact on the business. Involve them in thinking through how to maximize benefit to the business.
- Manage the successful installation of a new process or system under a tight deadline. Secure the right support and build a strong sense of commitment to making it a success.
- Lead a stalled project to successful completion within the next few weeks. Identify the issues and generate solutions to move it forward.
- Develop an actionable time line to improve performance in a group that has lost momentum. Dig deep for the reasons and take action to get them back on track.
- Create, champion, and track a fundraising campaign with a clear financial goal. Get creative about how it can be exceeded.

Take time to reflect...

If the goal ahead seems unattainable...

...then make it your mission to get others on board. Securing the commitment of the team is critical. Clarify the goal. Sell the vision. Share the plan. Define roles. Turn them loose.

If you've been pushing hard and don't see an end in sight...

...then remember the goal you are striving toward. Celebrate what you've achieved so far. Regroup. Plunge back in with renewed vigor.

If you can't face those last few steps of the task...

...then ask yourself what's holding you back. Inspiration and aspiration are just the start. Action is what will take you across the finish line. Craft a plan. Carve out the time. Focus on the goal in sight.

*"One never notices what has been done;
one can only see what remains to be done."*

Marie Curie – Polish and naturalized-French physicist and chemist



Learn more about **Drives** results

Baldoni, J. (2006). *How great leaders get great results*. New York, NY: McGraw-Hill.

Hiam, A. (2003). *Motivational management: Inspiring your people for maximum performance*. New York, NY: AMACOM.

- Meier, J. D. (2010). *Getting results the agile way: A personal results system for work and life*. Bellevue, WA: Innovation Playhouse, LLC.
- Myers, B. (2012). *Take the lead: Motivate, inspire, and bring out the best in yourself and everyone around you*. New York, NY: Atria Paperback.
- Thomas, K. W. (2009). *Intrinsic motivation at work: What really drives employee engagement* (2nd ed.). San Francisco, CA: Berrett-Koehler Publishers.



Deep dive learning resource links

- Driscoll, M. (2013, July 18). Research: Why companies keep getting blind-sided by risk. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*. Retrieved from <http://blogs.hbr.org/2013/07/research-why-companies-get-blindsided/>
- Giang, V. (2012, March 18). *15 Ways to stop procrastinating right now*. Business Insider. Retrieved from <http://www.businessinsider.com/15-ways-to-stop-procrastinating-right-now-2012-3?op=1>
- Gleeson, B. (2012, December 28). Setting stretch goals: All in, all the time. *Inc.* Retrieved from <http://www.inc.com/brent-gleeson/setting-stretch-goals.html>
- Grant Halvorson, H. (2011, June 22). How to become a great finisher. *Harvard Business Review Blog Network*. Retrieved from <http://blogs.hbr.org/2011/06/how-to-become-a-great-finisher/>
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- Llopis, G. (2013, April 1). The 12 things that successfully convert a great idea into a reality. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/glennllopis/2013/04/01/12-things-successfully-convert-a-great-idea-into-a-reality/>
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- Mind Tools. (n.d.). *Taking initiative: Making things happen in the workplace*. Mind Tools. Retrieved from <http://www.mindtools.com/pages/article/initiative.htm>
- Russell, N. S. (2013, February 8). Six ways to get things done when you're not the boss. *Forbes*. Retrieved from <http://www.forbes.com/sites/deborahljacobs/2013/02/08/six-ways-to-get-things-done-when-youre-not-the-boss/>
- Sevier, R. A. (2006, September). Moving a team forward. *University Business*. Retrieved from <http://www.universitybusiness.com/article/moving-team-forward>
- Stolovitsky, N. (2010, August 4). *Planning for the unplanned: Including risk in your project management strategy*. Genius Project. Retrieved from <http://www.geniusproject.com/blog/pm-best-practices/planning-for-the-unplanned-including-risk-in-your-project-management-strategy/>
- Wilkinson, M. (2010, June 18). *Why perseverance is an essential quality to possess in the workplace*. Career Path 360. Retrieved from

<http://www.careerpath360.com/index.php/why-perseverance-is-an-essential-quality-to-possess-in-the-workplace-4-9318/>

Recommended search terms

If you'd like to explore *Drives* results further, try searching online using the following terms:

- Effectively reducing stress at work.
- Getting work done through others.
- Planning for unexpected problems at work.
- Risk management.
- Setting stretch goals for employees.
- Turning an idea into reality.



More help...

Go to www.kornferry.com/fyi-resources and link directly to the deep dive resources in this chapter. Visit the site often to see the additional resources that are uploaded on a regular basis.